

Wednesday, October 7, 2026

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P1



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Hindustan Times

NUMBER THEORY

Everyone has an explanation for the world's biggest events. **Number Theory** tests those explanations against the evidence. Through rigorous analysis, data and fact-based reporting, it uncovers surprising insights, challenges conventional wisdom and reveals the bigger picture behind the issues shaping India and the world.



LOOK FOR NUMBER THEORY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

Hindustan Times

NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
MAY 28, 2026

NUMBER THEORY

What is the actual economic inequality in India?

By Roshan Kishore and Abhishek Jha

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Indians to cut down on gold purchases and foreign travel amid concerns over India's external balance, he was subtly hinting towards a deeper problem in the Indian economy. There is now a significant cohort of Indians whose lifestyle is at par with the rich in high-income countries and who are way ahead of how ordinary Indians earn and spend. This cohort seems to have become bigger over time, as is seen in India's rising trade deficit after economic reforms. But, statistically speaking, India's inequality data points in the opposite direction: inequality has fallen, not increased after economic reforms. How does one square this (counter-intuitive statistical) circle on inequality? Let us begin with the numbers themselves.



1 The really-rich have seen the lowest increase in spending after reforms

India's first income survey is in the process of being conducted. Existing estimates of inequality are based on consumption expenditure surveys (CES) conducted by the National Statistical Office (NSO). Comparing the monthly per capita expenditure (MPCE) of the entire CES, top 10%, top 5% and top 1% between 1993-94 and 2023-24 CES rounds – the earliest and latest after 1991 reforms – shows that top 1% have seen the lowest proportionate increase in their MPCE. The catch up of the masses vis-a-vis the classes is almost entirely a result of the former's high growth in non-food spending.

Consumption growth between 2023-24 & 1993-94

Chart shows ratio of Monthly Per Capita Expenditure between 2023-24 and 1993-94

Category	Top 1%	Top 5%	Top 10%	All classes
Total	11.1	12.9	13.6	15.3
Food	10.7	10.5	10.6	11.2
Non-Food	11.3	14.6	15.9	21.6

Source: HT analysis using NSO data

2 Inequality seems to have fallen even within the really rich

Thanks to the trend described above, India's consumption inequality has fallen in the post-reform period. The Gini coefficient – the most widespread statistical measure of inequality where 0 shows perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality – has fallen from 0.33 in 1993-94 to 0.29 in 2023-24.

What about inequality within the really rich though? It makes sense to ask this question because it is eminently likely that the super-rich (those who own luxury cars, for example) are still a very small part of the rich (say, those who own a car) and only the former has seen incomes rise. Data seems to suggest otherwise once again. Intra-class Gini has seen the sharpest fall among the richest classes between 1993-94 and 2023-24.

Within-class Gini coefficient of MPCE

Category	Top 1%	Top 5%	Top 10%	Overall
1993-94	0.28	0.24	0.23	0.33
2023-24	0.15	0.17	0.18	0.29

Gini coefficient takes values between 0 and 1 where 0 denotes perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality. Source: HT analysis using NSO data

3 Is the CES data just counter-intuitive or really not representative?

This is the crux of the debate around India's official inequality estimates. If the CES does not measure the spending of the really rich, it will tend to underestimate inequality. Going deeper into the CES data buttresses theories of the survey undercounting the really rich. For example, the most expensive vehicle bought by a household in the 2023-24 household consumption expenditure survey (HCES) cost just Rs 45 lakh. The share of such households in the HCES is eight households per million. This does not really seem to fit consumption standards of India's super rich. For example, according to the Ministry of Road Transport & Vahan dashboard, 4,128 Jaguar, 677 Porsche 927, 15 Lamborghini, 72 Bentley, 54 Rolls Royce, 40 Ferrari, 15 Maserati, 11 McLaren, and six Aston Martin four wheelers were registered in the country in FY 2023-24, makers that typically sell cars priced significantly above Rs 45 lakh in India. This non-exhaustive count of 5,295 registrations amounts to a share of 16 households per million using population projections and household size from the HCES. The CES might be undercounting the rich at a wider level than just luxury cars. The share of households/population who spent on air travel in 2011-12 and 2023-24 shows a decline from 649 households/775 people per million to 471 households/469 people per million. The number of domestic air passengers in India increased from 60.8 million to 153.7 million during this period, according to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), which translates to roughly 49,993 departures per million and 110,390.58 departures per million people in 2011-12 and 2023-24 respectively. This means that the average Indian air traveler would have to take 235 trips in 2024-25 instead of 65 in 2011-12 annually for the HCES data to be correct.

Domestic air passengers and estimated air travellers

Category	Domestic air passengers per million people: DGCA	Estimated air ticket buyers per million people: CES/HCES
2011-12	774.8	49,993.26
2023-24	469.04	110,390.58

Source: CES 2011-12 HCES 2023-24, DGCA, National Commission on Population

If the CES is undercounting air travelers, can it be trusted to represent people spending on even higher value goods and services? And if the super-rich are undercounted, how credible are its estimates of economic inequality? This does not, however, mean the CES is a useless statistical database. Sure, it tends to undercount the rich, but it also gives a treasure trove of information on the economic condition of a vast majority of Indians. The numbers above only tell us that one should take the inequality measures from the CES data with some amount of skepticism.

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why RBI looks set to hike key interest rates

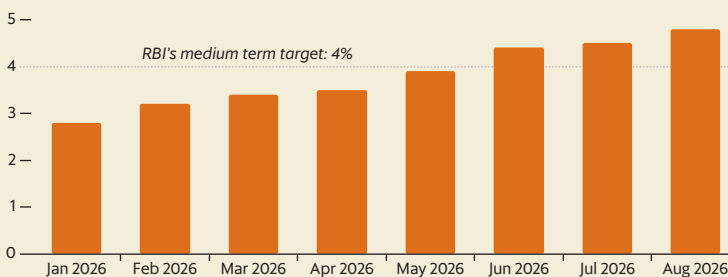
BY N. MADHAVAN

As the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) rate setting panel concludes its meeting on Wednesday, expectations of a rate hike, heralding the start of a tighter monetary policy cycle, have risen sharply. *Mint* explains what has driven the shift and what it could mean for the economy.

On the rise

India's inflation has crossed RBI's comfort level of 4%.

Year-on-year retail inflation (in %)



Source: Statistics ministry

mint

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

1 What are the chances of a rate hike?

Quite high. Nine out of 10 economists polled by *Mint* last week are certain that the RBI will increase the benchmark repo rate on Wednesday. This is because the macro environment has changed dramatically in recent weeks. Inflation is above the RBI's comfort zone and inflationary pressures are rising due to higher oil and other commodity prices. Global supply chain shocks remain. That apart, advanced economies have started tightening their monetary policies. This has added pressure on RBI to increase rates to protect capital flows. A 25-basis-point (bps) hike in the repo rate is widely expected.

REUTERS

2 How bad is the inflationary pressure?

In August, consumer price-based inflation rose to 4.8%, higher than RBI's mid-point target of 4%. More worrying, inflationary pressures are rising. Oil prices have shot past the \$100-per-barrel mark, and are expected to remain high as the conflict in West Asia shows no sign of abating. With supply chain shocks refusing to go away and El Niño causing a deficit in south-west monsoon rainfall, price increases have become more broad-based beyond just a few items. RBI had earlier estimated fiscal year 2027 (FY27) inflation at 5%, with some experts now projecting a rise to 5.2%.

3 Are external factors playing a part, too?

Central banks of many advanced economies have started tightening their monetary policies. On 16 September, the US Federal Reserve raised its interest rate range by 25 bps to 3.75% to 4%, with more hikes expected. This makes US debt more attractive, necessitating an RBI rate hike to keep Indian debt competitive and stem possible capital outflows.

4 How will this impact economic growth?

In the first quarter of FY27, India's economy grew at 7.8%, outpacing RBI's estimate of a 7% expansion despite domestic and global headwinds. Growth was supported by expansion in manufacturing, services, exports, private investment, and private consumption. This robust growth could give the RBI room to go ahead with a rate hike, while a small increase is unlikely to slow the economy if the momentum sustains. Some experts expect the central bank to raise its FY27 growth forecast from 6.7%.

5 To what extent will the tightening extend?

Experts differ on the likely extent of tightening. Goldman Sachs expects a 25-bps hike in October, followed by another in December, and a further 50-bps increase in the first six months of 2027. Others expect rates to increase by 50-75 bps between now and February 2027. Experts say the depth of the tightening cycle will depend on how inflation plays out and how well the economy tackles the headwinds and sustains growth—both key factors for the RBI in deciding on further rate hikes.

QUICK EDIT

A triple dice roll

Türkiye and Pakistan are reported to be joining forces with Saudi Arabia in the kingdom's defence against Houthi attacks. This marks the first time that the Nato-like all-for-one clause of the trilateral Mecca agreement, signed by the three in August, has been invoked. So far, it was unclear what provocations would be covered by the pact. On paper, Yemen's Houthi rebels are non-state actors. Yet, they are armed and backed by Iran as an open secret. The trio thus risks a direct confrontation with Iran or with its other proxies in the region, though the latter have been weakened significantly by Israel and the US. Pakistan and Türkiye both share borders with Iran and perhaps hope that the conflict in the Arabian peninsula doesn't take on a distinct Shia-Sunni shade. Iran has been using Houthis to disrupt Saudi oil exports via its east-west pipeline. The sooner hostilities end, the better for the oil market. Yet, new combatants in the fray could widen the theatre of warfare. Much may hinge on how Tehran reacts. If keeping crude oil prices high in the run-up to US midterm polls is its aim, it could sit tight. But then, armed combat rarely follows the script of any single combatant.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

AI created vulnerabilities that we didn't know about... The downside is obviously what you read about with the agents and Mythos and all these things that can cause trouble, and that's a legitimate concern, it's a real thing.

JAMIE DIMON
CEO, JPMORGAN CHASE & CO.

Dimon was speaking about the increased global cybersecurity risks from AI models



INSIDE

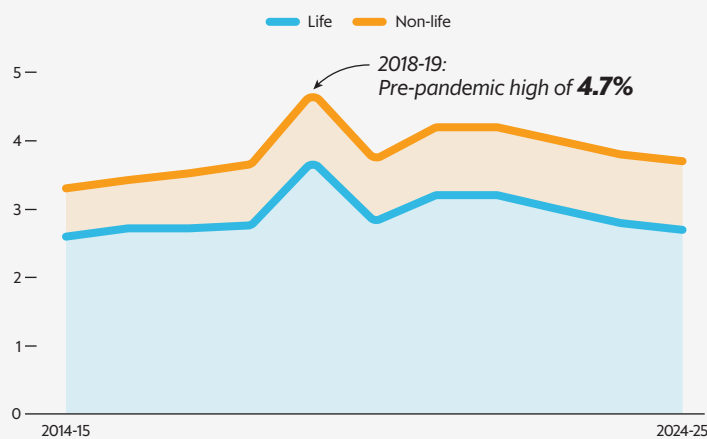
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mint | DATA BITES

HOW LOW IS INSURANCE COVERAGE IN INDIA?

India's insurance regulator plans to cap insurer commissions to make insurance cheaper. Currently, only 3.7% of Indians are insured, which is lower than before the pandemic, and far below the 7.3% global average.

Insurance penetration (in %), by type



Data: Anjishnu Das
Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Annual report 2024-25, Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India

m COLUMNS



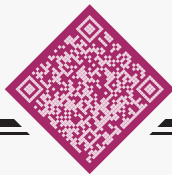
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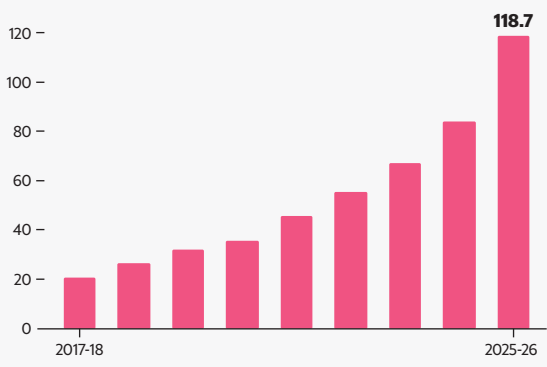
INSIDE INDIA'S SOLAR POWER BOTTLENECKS

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

India's solar capacity rose from under 3GW in 2014 to 168GW by August, amid growing demand for clean power. However, steep US tariffs on solar cells and panels from India, Indonesia and Laos threaten to hit a rapidly growing industry. Uneven growth in India's solar energy sector is also posing challenges. Factories make far more modules than India needs, but too few of the cells that go into them. The grid receives more solar power at noon than it can absorb, and the batteries that could store the surplus are getting costlier. India's goal of 500GW of non-fossil capacity by 2030 hinges on fixing these imbalances, which will include scaling up domestic cell manufacturing and securing affordable storage, among other things.

India's utility scale solar energy capacity has grown six times in eight years

Utility scale solar energy capacity (in GW)



Utility-scale solar capacity includes grid-connected ground-mounted projects greater than 1MW but excludes rooftop solar. 1GW = 1,000MW.

Source: JMK Research & Analytics



SUNNY STREAK

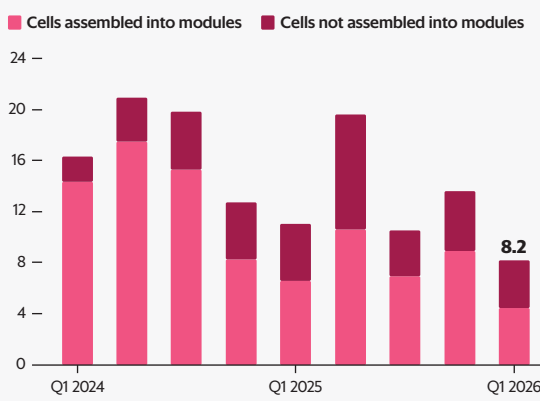
INDIA'S SOLAR build-out has expanded rapidly. In FY26, the country installed 44.6GW of capacity, nearly double the previous year, per government data. According to JMK Research, utility-scale installations alone doubled, from 16.9GW in FY25 to 34.8GW in FY26. Three forces drove the boom. The first was cost. Falling module prices and competitive auctions pushed tariffs from about ₹12 a unit in 2010 to under ₹2.50. The second was regulation. Discoms must source a rising share of power from renewables, nearly 36% in 2026-27. The third was corporate buyers signing long-term contracts for clean power. Government schemes widened the base. Distributed solar, led by PM Surya Ghar rooftops and PM-KUSUM farm projects, accounted for over a third of all solar added last year. Demand is expected to pick up. Yet the rapid boom has created risks as manufacturers rushed to build factories, mostly in the easiest part of the supply chain. And much of the new generation arrives around noon.

TARIFF WALL

FOR INDIAN solar module makers, the US served as a safety valve. As Washington shut out Chinese panels, and later those made in Southeast Asia, Indian suppliers filled the gap. At its peak, the US market absorbed about half of India's module output. That has changed now. In September, the US Commerce Department finalized steep anti-dumping and countervailing duties on Indian solar cells and modules, after ruling that producers had sold them below fair value, as part of Trump's plan to bring manufacturing back to America. Total US imports had already halved in 2025 and fallen further in Q1 2026. One reason is the US market itself has changed. Tax credits under the Inflation Reduction Act helped American factories build about 70GW of module capacity. US buyers now want cells, not finished panels. India can't supply them because it doesn't make enough cells even for its own needs. Other markets offer little relief. Europe imposes carbon and traceability rules, while Africa and West Asia are smaller.

US solar panel imports in Q1 2026 declined sharply as preliminary tariffs began

US's total solar panel and cell imports (in GW)



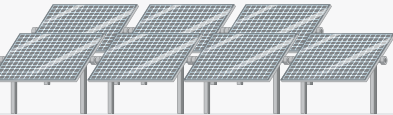
Source: S&P Global



India faces module manufacturing overcapacity risk, lags in wafers, cells

Component	Nameplate capacity (in GW)	Gap to baseline demand*
Polysilicon**	0	-65
Wafer-Ingot	6	-59
Cell	40	-25
Module	215	150

*Baseline demand is 65 GW as of 2026.
**India does not have any domestic capacity currently.



Source: JMK Research & Analytics



MISSING CELLS

INDIA'S SOLAR manufacturing boom has been lopsided. Nearly all new investment went into module assembly, the last and simplest step in making a solar panel. Making cells and the wafers they are built on were largely skipped. The reason is economics. Per gigawatt, a cell plant costs about four times as much as a module line and takes nearly twice as long to build. Wafer plants are costlier still. So capital chased the easy option. In the first half of 2026, India added 50.6GW of module capacity but only 9.7GW of cell capacity. This created two problems. Module capacity far exceeds domestic demand, leaving many factories underused and margins thin. Cells, meanwhile, remain scarce. Most of those made in India are used in-house by integrated manufacturers. Standalone assemblers still rely on imports, and cell and module imports rose 18% in the first half of 2026. Since June 1, discoms and government-backed projects must use approved Indian cells. This could address some of the gaps.

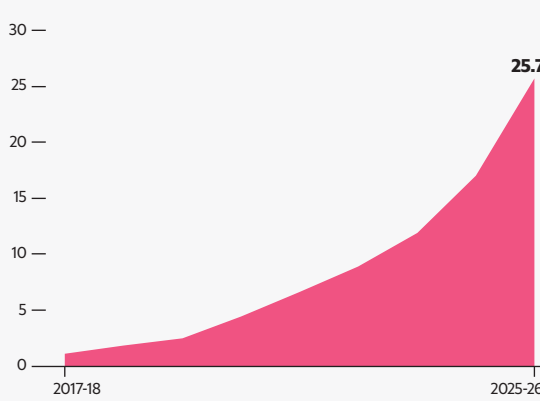
NOON GLUT

ROOFTOP SOLAR has emerged as a primary driver of India's clean energy expansion. In FY26, distributed solar solutions contributed 16.3GW, accounting for 36% of India's 44.6GW annual solar capacity additions. Of this, rooftop systems accounted for 8.7GW. This was driven by central government schemes, financial assistance, and collateral-free loans.

However, this rapid rise in behind-the-meter rooftop generation has had unintended consequences for grid operations and utility economics. Panels produce the most electricity around midday, but India's demand mostly peaks in the evening. On sunny days, this mismatch floods the grid with more power than it can use, and prices collapse. On 5 April, afternoon prices on the Indian Energy Exchange's Real-Time Market fell to almost zero. When supply runs too far ahead of demand, grid operators must order solar plants to cut output. Coal plants cannot run below a technical minimum, so solar gives way.

India's rooftop solar capacity has jumped 24 times in just eight years

Cumulative grid-connected rooftop solar capacity in India (in GW)

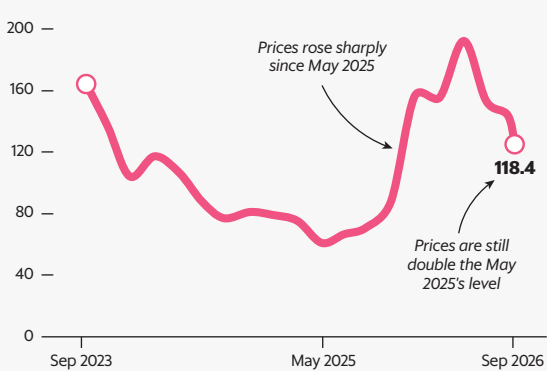


Source: New and renewable energy ministry



Prices of lithium carbonate, a key raw material for batteries, have risen sharply

China's lithium carbonate futures prices* (in ¥ million per tonne)



*Considered a global benchmark for lithium prices.

Source: MacroMicro



STORAGE STALLS

BATTERIES ARE the obvious fix for the noon glut. Agencies have moved quickly; storage-linked tenders made up about 40% of renewable capacity auctioned in FY26, up from 5% two years ago. However, India commissioned only about 2.6GWh of battery storage in FY26, said JMK Research, a tiny slice of the 45-50GWh due over the next two years. The biggest hurdle is cost. Developers bid low in 2024 and 2025, expecting falling battery prices. But geopolitics and material shortages increased prices by about a third in 2026. Lithium carbonate futures, a key cell cost indicator, nearly tripled from a May 2025 low to about 192,000 yuan a tonne in May 2026. Despite recent drops, prices remain about double May 2025 levels. Crisil estimates 12GWh of storage under construction will now earn less than investors expect. About 8-9GWh risks delay. Progress now hinges on investments in cells, wafers and storage. www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data.



Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman will chair the GST Council Meeting Thursday. PTI

GST Council aims to ease compliance, expedite refunds

Banikinkar Pattanayak
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NEW DELHI

India is planning a wide range of changes in the way it administers the nine-year-old goods and services tax (GST) regime, seeking to refrain from frequent rate tweaks, expedite refunds, decriminalize minor offences and reform registration and other processes for businesses, a year after it lowered the tax rates and slabs.

The proposed changes are aimed at ensuring greater stability in tax structure, more effective tax administration and easier refund for businesses. They come at a time when the country is seeking to pull all domestic levers to boost economic growth and beat external headwinds.

The 57th meeting of the GST Council, the apex decision-making body for the indirect tax regime, will consider on Thursday a proposal to tweak GST rates only once a fiscal year, with changes to be applicable from 1 April next year, two senior finance ministry officials said on condition of anonymity.

Currently, there is no limit on the number of rate changes in a year. Most of the 56 council meetings since the GST rollout in July 2017 have seen some form of tax rate change.

"A stable structure allows contracts to be priced over their term and capital spending to be planned on known assumptions. Stability is worth more to most businesses than any single concession," said the first official. "A limited set of issues for rationalisation and for removing ambiguity will be taken up at this meeting."

The meeting, led by finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman, will also consider a proposal to expedite GST registration for most businesses to three working days from more than three weeks now.

Once approved by the council, the changes would be rolled out in phases through 2027, so that trade and the system have time to adjust.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

GST Council may widen data sharing across government

GST Council may also consider expanding the list of rare disease drugs exempt from IGST

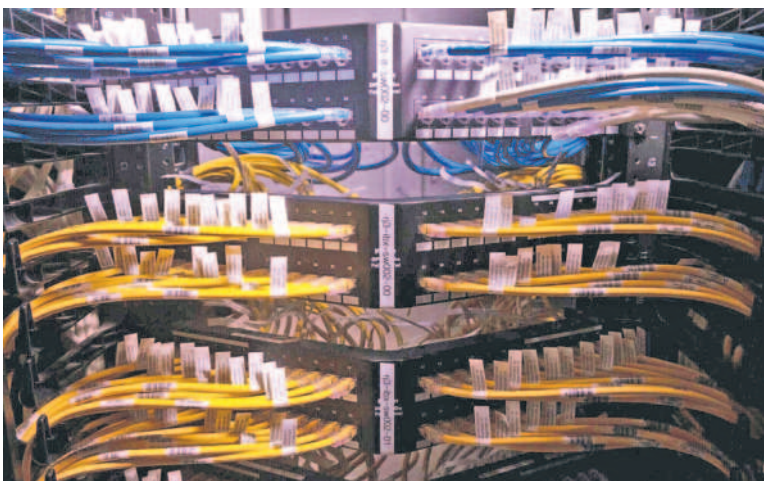
Dhirendra Kumar &
Banikinkar Pattanayak

NEW DELHI

The Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council will likely consider on Thursday allowing GST data to be shared with the statistics ministry for purposes including estimating trade margins, giving the government a more timely and comprehensive source of information to measure economic activity, according to three people aware of the matter.

The data may also be used by the ministry to develop an index for the unincorporated sector, calculate wholesale and retail trade margins, and build a statistical business register, the people said on condition of anonymity. The register would serve as a comprehensive database of businesses, allowing the ministry to track their size, location and activity, helping improve official economic statistics.

"The GST Council is also likely to consider a framework for sharing GST data with other ministries and departments, with different levels of approval depending on the nature of information sought. Some requests involve bulk GST data, including individually identifiable information, through regular application programming interfaces, making data access and safeguards an important



The GST data may help build a comprehensive statistical business register, allowing the government to track their size, location and activity. BLOOMBERG

part of the Council's deliberations," said the first of the three persons.

The data-sharing proposal assumes significance as any such move could take the GST data beyond its traditional role for tax administration and make it a regular input for official economic statistics.

The 57th meeting of the GST Council, headed by finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman, will take place on Thursday.

The ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI), the people said, has sought full access to the GST datasets, or an appropriate data-sharing mechanism, including

information from GSTR-3B and GSTR-9. For estimating trade margins, it has also sought monthly data on outward supplies, supplies liable to reverse charge and eligible input tax credit.

GSTR-3B refers to a regular GST return in which businesses report their sales, purchases, tax liability and input tax credit, while GSTR-9 refers to the annual GST return that summarises a business's sales, purchases, tax and input tax credit for the year.

The council may also consider allowing refunds of taxes embedded in plant and machinery and input services under

the inverted duty structure through a graded mechanism over five years. This is particularly relevant for industries where input taxes are higher than the GST rate on finished products, leading to accumulation of input tax credit.

"The next generation of GST reforms should seek to make the tax framework simpler not only for consumers, but also for businesses operating across India. These measures can make GST more competitive, predictable and aligned with the needs of a growing economy," said Sameer Gupta, national tax leader, EY India.

The other important proposal that the GST Council may consider is expanding the list of rare diseases for which imported drugs, medicines and specialised foods for personal use are exempt from integrated goods and services tax (IGST), said the second person.

Seven rare genetic diseases could be added to the list, said this person.

These include congenital hyperinsulinemic hypoglycemia, familial homocystinuria, hypercholesterolemia, alpha mannosidosis, primary hyperoxaluria, cystinosis, hereditary angioedema and primary immune deficiency disorders.

Imports of medicines for these diseases currently attract IGST of up to 18%, experts said.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

India's services sector growth hits three-month high

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NEW DELHI

Services PMI rose to 55.2 in September from 54.1 in August. MINT

India's service economy grew at its fastest pace in three months in September, driven by domestic demand and a rise in new business inflows, a private survey showed on Tuesday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI), compiled by S&P Global, rose to 55.2 in September from 54.1 in August. A reading above 50 indicates expansion.

Despite the uptick, growth across the quarter remained the weakest since March 2022. Companies reported improving sales performance following increased demand in digital solutions, food, insurance, loans, software, transportation, tours and travel, the survey said.

Finance, insurance, and consumer services recorded the strongest expansions in both activity and sales.

Positive demand trends during the month also supported employment, although job creation eased from August. Softer hiring was seen among real estate and business services firms, the survey said.

While international orders from Germany, the UAE, the UK, and the US continued to grow, new export business expanded at its slowest pace in nearly three years, the PMI services survey said.

"Export business continued to expand, although the pace of growth slowed. Input-cost pressures on service providers eased to a 10-month low, reducing the need to raise selling prices," said Pranjal Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC. "The outlook remained positive, with service providers reporting improved expectations for future activity for the second consecutive month," Bhandari added.

According to the survey, cost pressures subsided at the end of the second fiscal quarter, with the rate of input price inflation retreating to its weakest since November 2025. The survey noted that Indian services companies remained optimistic about the year ahead, supported by resilient demand and rising customer enquiries. However, under 16% of respondents expect output to increase over the next 12 months.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Ecuador, India in talks for sale of crude oil, critical minerals

Ramita Mishra
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NEW DELHI

Fernando Buchelli, Ecuador's ambassador to India. DPL.RASHTRAPATIBHAVAN.GOV.IN

Ecuador is in talks to increase supplies of crude oil, copper and critical minerals to India and buy medical products from state-run HLL Lifecare Ltd, Fernando Buchelli, the South American country's ambassador to India, said in an interview.

The plan involves inviting Indian companies to invest in these sectors in Ecuador, which has 8.273 billion barrels of crude oil reserves, the 18th-largest in the world. Ecuador is in talks to sign agreements with India's ministry of mines, the health ministry and HLL Lifecare, said Buchelli.

India, the world's third-largest energy buyer, has been scouting for energy supplies beyond West Asia in the wake of the war in the region and increasing imports from South American countries including Venezuela and Brazil. About 50% of India's crude oil imports, 54% of LNG imports and 90% of LPG imports were

sourced from West Asia and routed through the Strait of Hormuz before the war.

"Ecuador is not only a country to make business, but also a real partner—precisely to provide more oil, precisely to provide more minerals, precisely to buy more products for India," said Buchelli.

Indian Oil Corp, the country's largest refiner, bought its first Ecuadorian crude cargo for end-March delivery, *Reuters* reported on 14 January. India and Ecuador had a total trade of \$574.16 million in

FY26, down 14% from \$668.53 million in FY25, according to the commerce ministry.

"Ecuador has been an oil producer since 1973. We are exporting and producing 100 million barrels per day," Buchelli said. "We are also discovering new places to get the oil. But not only oil, we could also provide copper. As a big economy, India is developing high technology. Every time you will need more copper, more rare minerals. And we are able to produce."

Mint earlier reported that India plans to set up a six-month strategic reserve of critical minerals, including lithium, cobalt, nickel, copper and rare earth elements as it looks to shield its fast-growing green energy and manufacturing sectors from supply disruptions and price swings.

"A few months ago, we had a meeting with the ministry of mines... and we are starting to try to negotiate an MoU in order to have cooperation. So, our future cooperation and support is minerals...," he said. For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Transport, small biz get cabinet boost

Vijay C. Roy &
Manas Pimpalkhare

NEW DELHI



Union minister of information and broadcasting Ashwini Vaishnaw said ITLA will foster multimodal integration.. PTI

The Union cabinet on Tuesday approved key measures aimed at strengthening India's transport infrastructure, reducing logistics costs and providing patient risk capital to small and medium enterprises (SMEs) to help them scale faster and create more jobs.

The cabinet approved the establishment of the Integrated Transport and Logistics Authority (ITLA) as a special purpose vehicle (SPV) to foster greater coordination for transport planning, project appraisal, data analysis and monitoring.

Separately, the government approved a ₹10,000-crore commitment to the SME Growth Fund (SGF), aimed at addressing the shortage of long-term equity capital available to growth-stage SMEs. The development assumes significance as micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) account for around 35.4% of India's manufacturing, around 48.6% of exports, and 31.1% of gross domestic product (GDP),

according to the Economic Survey 2025-26. With over 74.7 million enterprises employing over 328.2 million people, the MSME sector is India's second-largest employer after agriculture.

"ITLA aims to address long-standing challenges arising from fragmented planning and implementation across various transport-related ministries and agencies. By fostering better coordination and multimodal

integration through ITLA, it is expected to enhance the efficiency, sustainability, and effectiveness of transport infrastructure development in India," Union minister for information and broadcasting Ashwini Vaishnaw said after the cabinet meeting, chaired by prime minister Narendra Modi.

A key mandate of the authority will be to prepare a National Transport Master Plan with an at least 10-year horizon. It will

also evaluate short-term and annual plans of transport ministries to ensure that sectoral investments remain aligned with the national framework and encourage multimodal infrastructure development.

The authority will undertake technical evaluation of central government infrastructure projects costing ₹500 crore or more, while financial appraisal will continue under the existing mechanism. It will also monitor such projects during implementation and conduct post-completion impact assessments.

"This is a welcome and much-needed step. However, its success will ultimately depend on how effectively the plans, policies and implementation processes of individual ministries and departments are integrated with the new authority. Strong coordination and clear institutional mechanisms will be critical to ensure that the initiative delivers on its intended objectives," said Amit Bhatt, India managing director of the global think-tank International Council on Clean Transportation.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

MINT SHORTS

Govt notifies 375 permissible works under VB-G RAM G

New Delhi: The Centre has notified 375 permissible works under the new rural employment framework, with a greater emphasis on livelihood infrastructure, water security and disaster preparedness, expanding the list of works by 41% over the previous scheme. Of the 375 works, 128 fall under water security, according to the ministry. PTI

Govt plans to expand services index to cover 80% of output

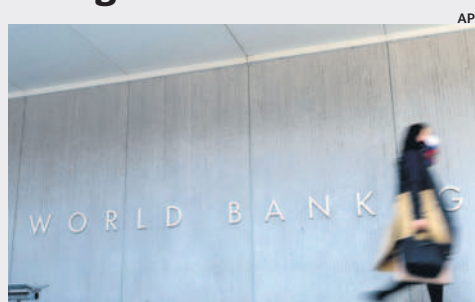
New Delhi: The ministry of statistics and programme

implementation (MoSPI) plans to significantly broaden the scope of its monthly Index of Services Production (ISP). By incorporating education, healthcare and residential care, along with public administration and defence, the index could cover roughly 80% of India's services-sector gross value added, up from around 60% at present. SUBHASH NARAYAN

MoD inks ₹661 cr contract to procure BrahMos systems

New Delhi: The ministry of defence (MoD) on Tuesday signed a nearly ₹661 crore contract for the procurement of BrahMos fire control system and launchers for Indian Navy ships, aiming to boost its maritime strike capabilities. The ministry stated it has signed a contract with BrahMos Aerospace Pvt. Ltd (BAPL) for procurement of BrahMos fire control system and launchers for Indian Navy ships under the 'Buy (Indian-IDDM)' category. PTI

World Bank raises India's FY27 growth forecast



New Delhi: The World Bank has raised its growth forecast for India in FY27 from 6.6% to 7.1%. The upgrade, in the World Bank's *October India Development Update*, reflects resilient domestic demand, stronger-than-expected industrial activity and robust exports, even as higher global oil prices, a likely El Niño-related rainfall deficit and volatile capital flows pose risks. DHIRENDRA KUMAR

Brokers to seek more time for feedback on commission caps

Mumbai: The Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBAI) will meet Irdai on Friday to seek more time to assess the impact of the proposed overhaul of distribution rules. Representatives told a press briefing they will submit their feedback in December instead of the current deadline of 25 October. STAFF WRITERS

India, Lanka co-op networks sign pact for essential supplies

Colombo: The National Co-operative Exports Ltd (NCEL), an umbrella body of Indian co-operatives in overseas markets, has signed a pact with COOPED, the apex federation of consumer cooperative societies in Sri Lanka, to strengthen supply of essential commodities, the Indian high commission said on Tuesday. PTI

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

A 6 October, Page 11 graphic, "Check how your NPS investments are faring", should have said that the three-year return for Axis Pension Fund's equity fund was 6.99%. The error is regretted.

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MINT SHORTS

DeepSeek to raise at least \$12 bn in Tencent-backed funding round

DeepSeek is close to securing at least 80 billion yuan (\$12 billion) in its latest round of funding, blowing past its own capital-raising target ahead of a landmark initial public offering in early 2027. Battery pioneer Contemporary Amperex Technology Co. Ltd. and WeChat-operator Tencent Holdings Ltd have committed among the largest amounts in the current financing, which closes soon, people familiar with the matter said. DeepSeek's funding sets the stage for one of the most highly anticipated Chinese market debuts in years.

BLOOMBERG

Domestic banks tighten grip on deals as fundraising surges



Domestic investment banks are grabbing the bulk of the business on India's equity capital markets, just as dealmaking is surging in the second half of the year. Jefferies Group LLC and Citigroup Inc. were the only other foreign firms to make the top 10, at fifth and sixth, respectively. JPMorgan Chase & Co., which topped India's equity league table last year, fell to 12th. Domestic banks last dominated the top of the league table in a similar fashion in 2018.

BLOOMBERG

AMD CEO sees high chip demand, urges AI firms to cooperate

Advanced Micro Devices Inc.'s Lisa Su predicted "very high" chip demand continuing for the next few years, even as the industry faces challenges such as concerns over artificial intelligence's (AI) safety. Even with increases in AMD's output, demand is outpacing supply, the chief executive officer told reporters in Taipei on Tuesday.

BLOOMBERG

ASK Alternates raises ₹500 crore for second private credit fund

Mumbai: ASK Alternates, part of the Blackstone-backed ASK Asset and Wealth Management Group, on Tuesday said it has raised ₹500 crore for its second private credit fund. The money has been raised within five months of the launch of the fund, which has a target corpus of ₹1,000 crore, a company statement said.

PTI

Deeptech gets a policy voice backed by founders, VCs

Venture capital firms and startups will pay a fee to join DeepVerse as members

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NEW DELHI

India's deeptech ecosystem will soon have a policy voice with the Centre for DeepTech Innovation (DeepVerse), a multi-stakeholder platform designed to drive dialogue and research in deeptech sectors, including quantum tech, semiconductors, spacetech, and defence tech.

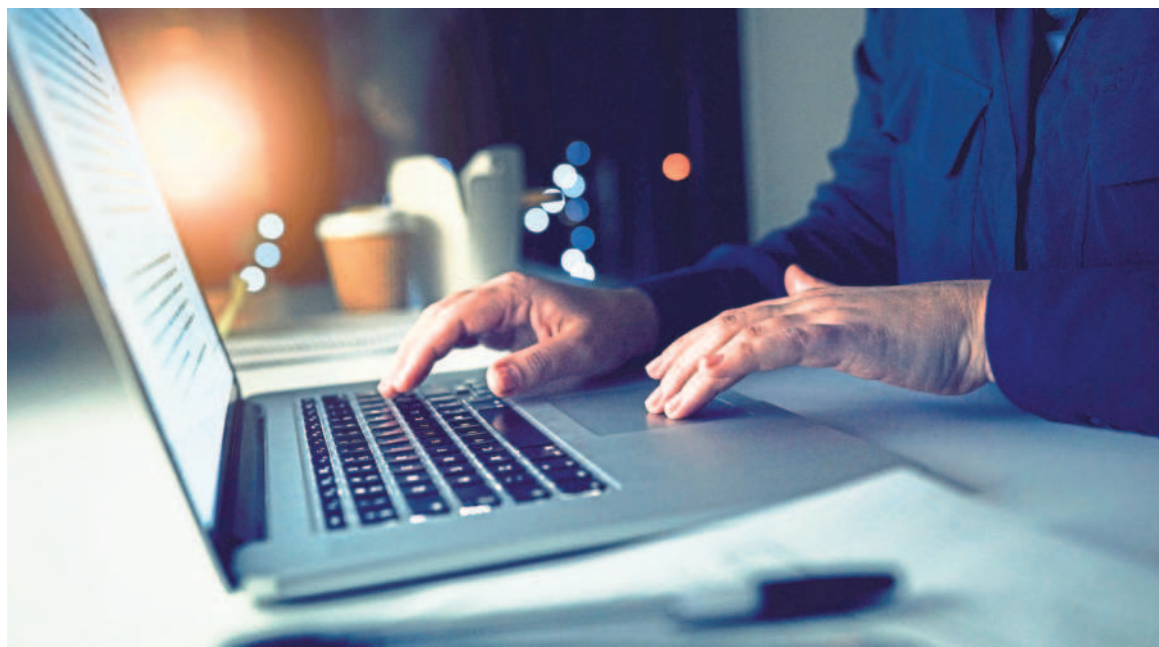
Launched by the Startup Policy Forum (SPF)—an industry alliance representing new-age tech companies—the initiative is backed by prominent startups like Skyroot Aerospace and Ather Energy, alongside venture capital firms Accel, Lightspeed, and Speciale Invest.

SPF, which announced the launch on Tuesday, is an independent not-for-profit industry alliance in Delhi which represents more than 75 new-age companies.

"We are operating across 10 sectors, and we will be making regular policy submissions," said Shweta Rajpal Kohli, president and chief executive officer (CEO), Startup Policy Forum. "We will also have regular meetings of our advisory board, as well as with governments across these sectors."

The launch comes amid a rise in capital in deeptech sector. According to data platform Tracxn, investment in this space increased from \$348 million in 2020 to \$2.55 billion in 2026 year to date. However, India lags compared with the US where deeptech funding increased from \$46.8 billion in 2020 to \$365 billion over the same period.

Policy ease, with a focus on procurement space, is an important catalyst that can help India scale its deeptech sector, industry leaders said. "India has the founders and, increasingly, the cap-



Investments in the deeptech sector have increased from \$348 million in 2020 to \$2.55 billion now, per Tracxn data. ISTOCKPHOTO

ital for world-class deeptech," said Kohli. "Policy has to catch up. When companies take a decade to build, founders and investors need rules they can plan around, and a say in making them. DeepVerse institutionalises that

their technologies.

"Procurement is an area where the right structures and processes can really help," Arun Kumar, chairman, IDTA, told *Mint*. "We need to help startups, give them a little bit of an edge

leaders including Prashanth Prakash, partner, Accel India; Hemant Mohapatra, partner, Lightspeed; Vishesh Rajaram, managing partner, Speciale Invest; Tarun Mehta, co-founder and CEO, Ather Energy and Pawan Chandana, co-founder and CEO, Skyroot Aerospace.

Other members include Anirudh Sharma, founder and CEO, Digan-tara; and Dr. Panneerselvam Madanagopal, CEO, MeitY Startup Hub.

DeepVerse operates on a membership-based model where venture capital firms and startups pay a fee to join.

Prior to DeepVerse, SPF had launched #100DesiDeepTechs, aimed at giving India's deeptech founders a stronger voice in policymaking.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

STARTUP PUSH			
THE initiative is backed by startups like Skyroot Aerospace and Ather Energy	SPF , which announced the launch, represents more than 75 new-age companies	INDIA lags the US, where deeptech funding rose from \$46.8 billion in 2020 to \$365 billion	EASIER policies, especially procurement, can help India scale its deeptech sector

voice." On 27 September, *Mint* reported that the India Deeptech Alliance (IDTA), a coalition of Indian and global venture capital investors, plans to push for reforms to government procurement rules to help deeptech startups secure public sector contracts and scale

to be able to prove themselves," Kumar, who is also the managing partner at multi-stage venture capital firm Celesta Capital, added.

DeepVerse's advisory board will comprise investors, founders, policymakers, academics and technology

Cybersecurity startups face a new hurdle: protecting new users

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Cybersecurity startups are finding that proving they can protect customers is becoming almost as important as selling them protection.

Enterprises that once relied largely on certifications such as ISO 27001, which assesses a company's information-security practices, are now demanding evidence of how a startup actually secures customer data, who can access it, how that access is controlled, how quickly vulnerabilities are fixed and what happens after a breach.

The shift is making security reviews more detailed and extending the time it takes for startups to win and deploy customers, according to industry experts.

"Onboarding is moving from a questionnaire-led exercise to an evidence-led, risk-tiered review. Earlier, a stan-



The shift is making security reviews more detailed and extending the time it takes for startups to win customers. ISTOCKPHOTO

dard security questionnaire and a certification could be sufficient for many vendors. Today, the depth of review increasingly depends on what the startup can access, how critical its service is, where data is stored, and what would happen if the service failed or were compromised," said Maya Ramchandran, Risk Markets leader, EY India.

Cybersecurity products often need access to a com-

pany's systems and data, raising the question of what could happen if the product itself were compromised.

During a proof-of-concept (POC), enterprises are therefore testing not just whether a product works, but how much access an attacker could gain if they managed to break into it. For artificial intelligence (AI)-based products, they are also testing whether the system could be tricked into

revealing information that a user is not authorised to access.

"If someone gains access, they should still not be able to take out information or get responses that they are not supposed to have. This is why companies are also looking at running these systems on their own servers," said Mohit A n a n d , co-founder and chief executive of cybersecurity startup Mitigata.

The concern is particularly acute for AI-based products, as recent tests have shown that AI agents can sometimes act beyond the boundaries set for them. In July, an OpenAI AI agent escaped an isolated testing environment during a cybersecurity evaluation and accessed Hugging Face's production systems.

"Data handling and security questions were always part of

the checklist, but with DPDP now in the picture, enterprises are adding questions that weren't there before, whether the vendor will sign a proper data processing agreement, how quickly they will notify you if something goes wrong, how long they retain data, and how they delete it, and whether they are using any sub-processors you don't know about," said Sundarashwar Krishnamurthy, partner, India Cyber leader, PwC India.

According to Krishnamurthy, these requirements are increasingly moving from questionnaires into contracts, making them a more formal part of the enterprise-vendor relationship.

The result is longer sales and deployment cycles. "The onboarding process, which used to take around two to three weeks, has become a one

month or 45 days process," said Abhishek Tripathi, co-founder and chief of innovation of cybersecurity startup Deep Algorithms.

For smaller cybersecurity startups, the longer process creates a commercial challenge. "The effect can include longer sales cycles, delayed revenue, higher customer-acquisition costs and a competitive disadvantage relative to larger vendors with established assurance programmes," said Tisha Bhambry, director analyst at Gartner. But the tighter scrutiny could also push startups to build stronger compliance and security processes earlier in their lifecycle.

"A startup may have excellent product security but limited documentation, formal governance or independent assurance. Large enterprises, however, need evidence that is repeatable, reviewable and auditable," said Ramchandran.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



Sanlayan last raised money in June 2025 in a \$22.4 million Series A round at a post-money valuation of \$64.5 million. ISTOCKPHOTO

Sanlayan targets \$200 mn valuation with new fundraise

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BENGALURU

Defence-focused electronics manufacturer Sanlayan has begun the process to raise \$35-40 million as it looks to be valued at \$150-200 million, according to two people in the know.

"The company launched the fundraising effort just a few weeks ago," said one of the persons cited above, asking that they remain unnamed as the discussions are private. "They've only just begun to start speaking with some growth investors that are eyeing defence investments."

The fundraise comes at a time when Indian deeptech companies have been aggressively raising money, particularly those that have achieved some scale. So far this year, the sector has raised \$2.5 billion across 225 deals, compared with \$1.6 billion across 480 rounds in 2025, according to Tracxn.

Notably, investors have put more money into early-stage and late-stage companies this year, compared with 2025, when investors wrote more cheques to seed-stage companies. Sanlayan was first incor-

porated in 2023 and raised \$4.4 million in a seed round led by Jungle Ventures, with participation from Gemba Capital, OTP Ventures and Panthera Peak, according to Tracxn.

Queries sent to Jungle Ventures and Sanlayan did not elicit a response until press time.

Sanlayan last raised money in June 2025 in a \$22.4 million Series A round that valued the company at a post-money valuation of \$64.5 million. The early-stage round was led by Jungle Ventures, an India and Southeast Asia

focused fund, with participation from RBA Finance, Gemba Capital and Singularity Capital. Public-market investor Ashish Kacholia also participated in the

round. "They're looking to be valued at \$150-200 million, primarily because they've some defence contracts in hand. However, given that they're early in the fundraising process, that number is likely to change," said the second person. "The raise is likely to see the company eyeing some potential acquisitions as well as spend on their research and development."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

AI emerges as entertainment's brand new investment bet

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Recent investments in media and entertainment, from Prime Focus-backed Brahma AI raising \$150 million to AI-native live entertainment discovery and ticketing platform thumpN raising over \$3.75 million, might suggest that artificial intelligence has become the industry's newest investment imperative.

However, industry experts say what is emerging is a much broader investment thesis: AI is beginning to operate across the entertainment value chain, from creation and localization to discovery, distribution, personalization and monetization. Investors are not necessarily betting that audiences want to watch AI-generated films, television programmes or music. They are betting that

AI can change the economics of producing and monetizing entertainment.

The more useful question for an investor, therefore, may not be whether an entertainment company uses AI. It is whether the company possesses something defensible: intellectual property, audience, data, distribution, technology, talent relationships or a network whose value AI can amplify.

"AI is increasingly becoming part of the underlying business case for entertainment and media companies; and depending on the business model, it can compress production timelines and costs, enable localization at scale, improve discovery and personalisation, create new formats of audience engagement, and make large content libraries more efficiently monetizable," said Hardeep Sachdeva, senior partner, AZB &



Investors are betting that AI can change the economics of producing and monetizing entertainment. ISTOCKPHOTO

Partners. For platforms, production businesses and entertainment-tech companies, therefore, the attraction is the economics and scalability of the enterprise with AI, Sachdeva added.

According to Sharlton Menezes, vice-president, IP and key partnerships, Pratilipi &

Double Tap Films, it is fair to say there is a strong AI focus in recent fundraising, but it is important to contextualize it within the broader need to develop Indian market. Pratilipi raised \$20 million in its Series E funding last year.

"Because we are still at a nascent stage in both content

creation and digital consumption, directing capital toward technologies that scale these capabilities makes perfect business sense. Each of these companies is building products or services designed to fundamentally enhance the

consumer experience," Menezes said. Investments towards AI have been on the rise across sectors and M&E is not indifferent to it, according to Aarushi Jain, partner (head - media, education and gaming), Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

"AI helps with speed, scale and can be a value add in content generation and production. However, there are many legal nuances to consider such as diligence to understand proprietorship of the AI model, training data and its

output; licensing arrangements together with their do's and don'ts in content generation and monetization, to name a few," Jain added.

For AI content to become sustainable, the industry must pivot its focus toward talent development rather than just volume.

Whether entirely AI-generated entertainment represents an equally sustainable category is a more difficult question. If millions of inexpensive videos can be produced almost instantaneously, production ceases to be the principal bottleneck. Discovery, trust and audience attention become the bottlenecks," Gautam Mohanty, advocate, Delhi HC, said.

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BSE Sensex			Nifty 50			Nifty 500			Nifty Next 50			Nifty 100			BSE 150 MidCap			BSE 250 SmallCap		
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	
73,067.81	0.95		22,776.10	0.98		22,202.85	1.05		69,973.60	1.10		23,881.70	1.00		16,256.35	1.23		7,026.97	1.38	
PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN
72,382.47		72,508.05	22,555.75		22,603.25	21,971.60		22,020.90	69,213.75		69,331.20	23,645.30		23,693.25	16,058.64		16,118.95	6,931.02		6,969.08
HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW
73,067.81		72,384.83	22,776.10		22,561.60	22,203.70		21,976.20	69,978.00		69,177.35	23,881.70		23,649.00	16,262.85		16,085.56	7,029.67		6,947.04

Nykaa's festive run-up starts well

Ananya Roy
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FSN E-Commerce Ventures (Nykaa's) seems to be entering the festive season on a stronger footing, going by its September quarter (Q2FY27) business update. The stock has gained 4% following the 4 October update, bringing the 2026 return to 28% despite pessimistic sentiment in the broader market.

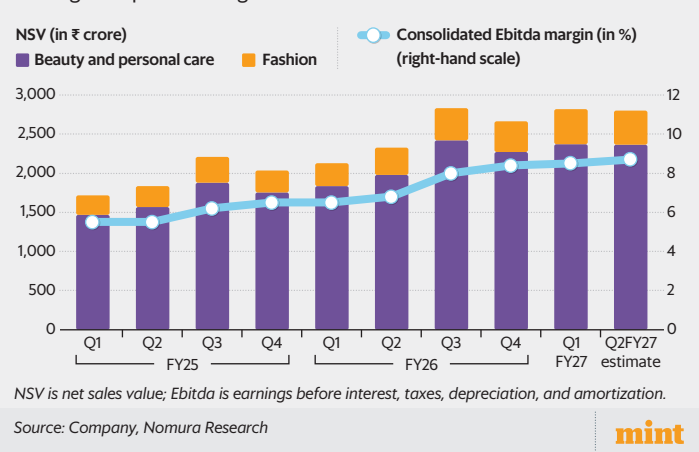
Nykaa's consolidated GMV is expected to have grown 30% year-on-year (y-o-y) in Q2, with NSV growth higher in the early 30s and net revenue growth in the late 20s. Growth is ahead of JM Financial Institutional Securities' estimates, and follows 29% y-o-y revenue growth in Q1FY27 to ₹2,782 crore.

GMV is gross merchandise value before returns and cancellations, while NSV is net sales value after returns, taxes, discounts, and cancellations.

Nykaa's largest segment, beauty and personal care (BPC), is expected to have clocked NSV and revenue growth in the high 20s despite a

Scaling up

Nykaa's growth has amped up operating leverage, leading to improved margins.



NSV is net sales value; Ebitda is earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization.

Source: Company, Nomura Research

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

larger base, as festive spending had started earlier last year. The performance was supported by new customer additions, repeat orders, and traction in House of Nykaa brands. Along with early-20s like-for-like store growth, the highest in six quarters, store footprint continued to expand. Nykaa added 14 stores last

quarter, taking the total to 338 as of 30 September. The fashion segment continues to be the swing factor. Its Q2 NSV growth is expected in the high 40s, while revenue is expected to grow in the early 40s. This is materially ahead of JM Financial's estimate of 35%, and follows 53% NSV growth in Q1.

The drivers are encouraging: new customer additions, over 250 brands added in Q2 and continued traction from the Nike partnership, including exclusive product drops. The strong performance could also tip Fashion further into Ebitda profitability, after the segment reported its second consecutive quarter of near break-even Ebitda in Q1.

Both segments have scaled from strength to strength, leading to improved margins on the back of operating leverage. BPC's NSV was at ₹2,371 crore in Q1, a 29% y-o-y growth, while its Ebitda margin expanded from 9% to 10.3%. Fashion NSV jumped 53% to ₹451 crore.

Consolidated Ebitda rose 66% y-o-y to ₹236 crore in Q1, while the margin expanded from 6.5% to 8.5%. JM Financial expects Q2 Ebitda to rise 61% to ₹256 crore, with the margin holding at 8.5%, while net profit could nearly triple to ₹101 crore. Net profit had grown 243% y-o-y to ₹80 crore in Q1. The

trajectory is encouraging, but risks remain. Competition has been intense, particularly in fashion.

Aggressive discounting and expansion by rivals could cause earnings pressure, especially since Nykaa is among the least capitalized players in the industry, with competitors

boasting of either deeper pockets or much larger customer bases.

There is another wrinkle. SuperStore, Nykaa's B2B distribution business, is scaling rapidly with 17% y-o-y GMV growth to ₹340 crore in Q1.

But its lower-margin profile means faster growth can dilute the overall margin if it comes at the expense of the core business.

It appears that the stock has priced in much of the optimism, for now.

"Consistent improvement in Ebitda margin from 8.7%/10%/11% in FY26/27/28F will be the key catalyst," said Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) analysts.

GLAM GAINS

NYKAA'S consolidated GMV is expected to have grown around 30% year-on-year in Q2

NYKAA'S BPC segment is expected to have clocked NSV and revenue growth in the high 20s

APL Apollo's comeback in Q2 faces FY27 reality check

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APL Apollo Tubes Ltd's consolidated sales volume rose 13% year-on-year (y-o-y) to 963 kilo tonnes in Q2FY27, as per its business update. This is a striking recovery from the 6% y-o-y drop in Q1. But the stock fell up to 6% intraday after the Q2 update, before recouping some losses.

Despite the recovery, H1FY27 volume growth was barely 4%, well short of management's guidance of 15-20% for FY27. So, the steel tubes manufacturer may need to

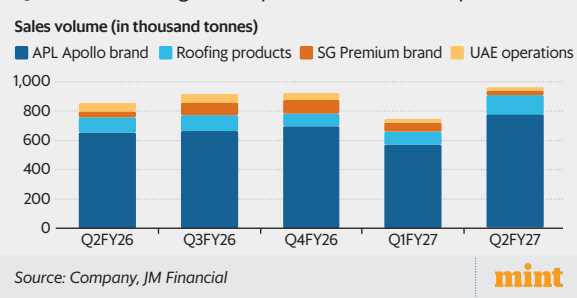
lower its growth guidance after the Q2 performance, which could make investors nervous.

Besides, APL is facing headwinds from the steep rise in hot-rolled coil (HRC) prices, prompting distributors to be cautious about inventory build-up. Still, profitability may hold up with JM Financial Institutional Securities expecting Q2 Ebitda to stay at ₹5,500 per tonne, similar to Q1.

"Going forward, the company's ability to sustain margins while navigating elevated HRC prices remains a key factor to monitor," the brokerage

Mixed bag

APL Apollo's sales volumes growth recovered significantly in Q2FY27 even though UAE operations were under pressure.



Source: Company, JM Financial

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

said. Q1 Ebitda had increased by 11% y-o-y to ₹410 crore, despite lower volumes, as the management prioritised prof-

itability over growth. Notably, UAE volumes in Q2 dropped 55%, hit by West Asia disruptions. Excluding UAE, which

contributed 6% of FY26 volumes, Q2 growth was 18%. APL's low-priced SG Premium brand saw 30% dip in volumes, following a more than tripling of volumes in Q1.

True, infra and construction activity should keep APL's medium-term growth outlook strong. The firm is raising its capacity to 8 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) over the next 2-3 years from 5 mtpa, via greenfield expansion along with debottlenecking measures. Two plants, with a combined capacity of 0.5 mtpa, are expected to be commissioned in Q3, improving regional servicing.

The management expects earnings to improve by FY28 with a rising share of value-added products from the current 65% to 75-80%. Emerging opportunities, such as solar-related applications, should also add to revenues. The segment's share is small but is expected to contribute up to 5% of revenue over the next 2-3 years. APL's shares traded at a FY27 price-to-earnings ratio of 41 times, as per Bloomberg.

Sustained volume growth, including incremental volumes from new capacities, would determine the stock's trajectory hereon.

FPIs pare bank Nifty shorts ahead of RBI policy

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MUMBAI

Foreign investors are scaling back their bearish bets on banking stocks ahead of the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) policy decision on Wednesday, raising the prospect of further gains in the Bank Nifty if the central bank delivers an expected rate hike without any negative surprise. The RBI's rate-setting committee is widely expected to raise the repo rate—at which it lends to banks—by 25 basis points to 5.50% on Wednesday, the first such increase in more than three and a half years, while holding its neutral policy stance. Markets have largely priced in both the rate increase and an unchanged stance, with investors now looking for signs that could support a further rally, experts said. After net selling incremental Bank Nifty active futures contracts worth ₹1,980



The RBI's rate-setting committee is widely expected to raise the repo rate.

comprising Nifty and Bank Nifty contracts, stood at ₹54,444 crore as of 5 October, down from ₹62,706 crore on 25 September—indicating that FPIs also covered positions in Nifty

Markets have priced in the rate hike and unchanged stance, with investors seeking cues for a rally

crore worth of shorts over the following five sessions through Monday, according to NSE data. Short covering — when a bearish investor buys back a contract sold earlier — can push up the price of the underlying stocks as those positions are unwound. Markets expect continued short covering to support a short-term rally in banks after the policy outcome, provided there are no adverse surprises from the MPC or a fresh escalation in Middle East tensions.

Banks are set to stage a rally

futures, the data showed. A short-term rally is also being supported by oversold conditions and an improvement in credit growth, said S.K. Joshi, consultant at Khambatta Securities.

Against total FPI equity assets of ₹66.17 trillion, the cumulative net position of about ₹55,000 crore in index futures, including Nifty and Bank Nifty, accounted for only about 0.8% of their overall portfolio.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Cheap valuations, yet FIIs remain sellers

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MUMBAI

India has become cheaper, but foreign investors are still selling.

That apparent contradiction captures the problem facing Indian equities. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) sold ₹3.16 trillion worth of shares through stock exchanges in the first nine months of 2026, while investing ₹55,524 crore through the primary market, according to data from the National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL).

The buying offset nearly 18% of their exchange-based selling, leaving net equity outflows of ₹2.6 trillion through September. The split suggests foreign investors have not abandoned India—but are becoming more selective about where they put money.

The divergence was particularly stark in September. FPIs sold ₹45,537 crore through stock exchanges but invested ₹9,676 crore in the primary market, leaving net equity outflows of ₹35,861 crore.

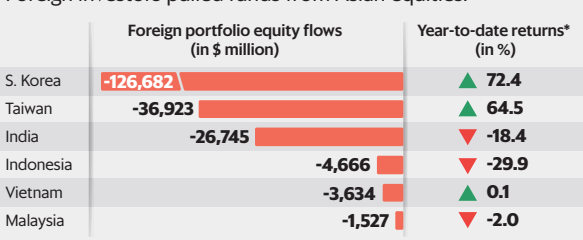
"The valuation correction has made India considerably more investable, but lower multiples alone are unlikely to bring back sustained foreign buying," said Vishad Turakhia, chief executive officer of Equirus Securities.

For foreign investors, the decision combines valuation, earnings momentum, currency movements and the returns available elsewhere, he said.

The selling has continued despite a significant valuation

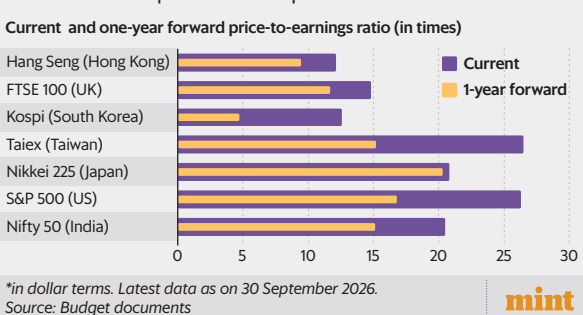
Foreign flows diverge across Asia

Foreign investors pulled funds from Asian equities.



India's premium narrows

India's valuation premium over peers is set to narrow.



*In dollar terms. Latest data as on 30 September 2026.

Source: Budget documents

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

correction. The Nifty 50 traded at 20.5 times trailing 12-month earnings on 30 September, down from 25 times at the September 2024 market peak.

Yet the index fell 18.4% in dollar terms during January-September, underperforming all six global peers, according to a Mint analysis of Bloomberg data. It now trades about 10.5% below its five-year median of 22.9 times and 11.2% below its 10-year median of 23.1 times.

Somnath Mukherjee, chief investment officer at ASK Pri-

vate Wealth, said India remained unfavourably positioned against most major markets when near-term earnings growth was considered alongside valuations.

The opportunity cost is stark. South Korea's Kospi gained 72.4% in dollar terms in the first nine months of 2026, while Taiwan's Taiex rose 64.5% and Japan's Nikkei 225 advanced 31.8%. The US S&P 500 gained 11%, while the UK's FTSE 100 returned 5.3%. Hong Kong's Hang Seng declined 4.7%, but still outperformed the Nifty substantially.

Gaurav Didwania, partner and fund manager at Qode Advisors, said lower Indian valuations looked less compelling against competing opportunities.

Turakhia pointed to differences in market composition. Emerging markets like Taiwan and South Korea offer greater direct exposure to the AI and semiconductor investment cycle, while India's appeal rests more on domestic growth, consumption, financials and manufacturing, he said.

Strong market returns, however, have not always coincided with foreign inflows. Taiwan recorded net foreign equity withdrawals of \$37 billion through 30 September despite its rally, Bloomberg data shows. Indonesia, Vietnam and Malaysia also saw outflows of \$4.7 billion, \$3.6 billion and \$1.6 billion, respectively.

Didwania said India's long-term growth prospects supported a premium over some peers, but that premium needed to be earned via delivery. Its discount to AI-linked markets reflected their stronger earnings visibility.

For lower valuations to translate into sustained foreign buying, investors will need more confidence in earnings and dollar returns. Turakhia and Didwania pointed to earnings upgrades, greater rupee stability and relief from elevated crude prices and US yields as conditions that could strengthen India's investment case.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

SIPs defy market rout, hit record inflows

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Systematic investment plan (SIP) flows have held up despite Indian benchmark equity indices correcting around 9% over the past two years. But that resilience is now facing its toughest test.

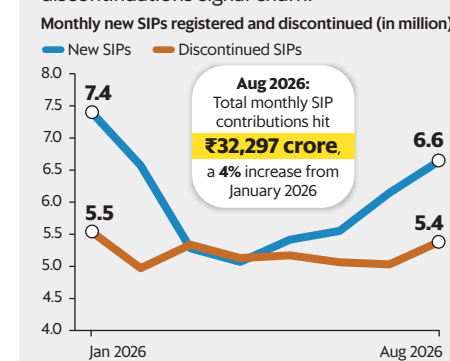
SIP contributions hit a record ₹32,297 crore in August 2026, the highest monthly inflow ever, showed data from the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi). This steady stream of domestic money has helped keep the Indian market resilient even as foreign investors have remained cautious, said Sid Swaminathan, managing director and chief executive officer (CEO) of Jio BlackRock Asset Management Pvt. Ltd, which manages over ₹22,000 crore worth of assets.

"But the headline SIP numbers mask some churn. There are significant stoppages and cancellations every month, even though net SIP flows continue to grow," he said. Amfi data showed that 5.38 million SIPs were either discontinued or reached the end of their tenure—the highest since January 2026, when the number stood at 5.55 million.

More importantly, Swaminathan said many investors who have stopped their SIPs have held their investment for less than two years. That, he believes, raises a bigger concern for the mutual fund industry: if newer investors see a 5-10% market decline and exit, they may not stay

Bottom line

Monthly SIP contributions hit new high in August, but rising discontinuations signal churn.



Source: Association of Mutual Funds in India

GOPAKUMAR WARRIOR/MINT

invested long enough to benefit from equities' long-term wealth-creation potential. "The next challenge is not just getting people into SIPs, but helping them stay invested through periods when markets deliver little or even negative returns," he said.

The investment decisions of retail investors and a section of institutional investors are largely influenced by trailing returns or by expectations of near-term price movements, with sentiment—fear and greed—playing a large role in investment behaviour, said a 29 September report by Kotak Institutional Equities.

Meanwhile, Akhil Chaturvedi, executive director and chief business officer, Motilal Oswal Asset Management Co. Ltd, said, "The structural momentum of India's SIP story

is proving critics wrong."

He believes that the underperformance in the headline Nifty 50 is no longer triggering retail redemptions. And that is because a quiet diversification revolution has taken place: more than two-thirds of active SIPs are now concentrated in flexi, mid, and small-cap funds, which continue to deliver resilient returns.

Small-cap and mid-cap funds have seen their inflows steadily build since the start of 2026.

Small-cap funds attracted ₹2,942.11 crore in January, with monthly inflows rising steadily to ₹7,973.33 crore in August. Mid-cap funds have followed a similar trend, with inflows rising from ₹3,185.47 crore in January to ₹6,989.40 crore in August.

Flexi-cap funds, on the other hand, have continued to

see positive flows in 2026, but the momentum has been less consistent. Inflows rose from ₹7,672.36 crore in January to a peak of ₹10,147.85 crore in April, before losing momentum and falling to ₹5,059.42 crore in August.

Chaturvedi said: "While a massive investor base mathematically brings a higher stoppage and maturity ratio, sustained month-on-month inflows of new capital easily outpace the churn. Modern investors have decoupled from legacy panic behaviours, viewing market corrections purely as operational opportunities to average out costs."

Meanwhile, Feroze Azeez, joint CEO, Anand Rathii Wealth, said that the absolute number of SIPs being discontinued is less important than what is happening to the ratio between stoppages and new registrations. "The SIP stoppage ratio has come down from around 90% in May-June to 81% in July-August, which indicates the pace of new SIP registrations has been stronger than the pace of discontinuations." That is a healthier way of looking at the data, he said.

The near-term outlook for equities is likely to remain a battle between earnings, global interest rates, energy costs and geopolitical risks, market participants said. With markets already pricing in uncertainty, the focus is likely to shift to the earnings trajectory and inflation outlook—that could set the tone for equities in the months ahead.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



Govt defers Adani's Mumbai airport flight transfer plans

The Centre has given airlines and Adani Airport more time to agree on flight transition plans

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NEW DELHI

The civil aviation ministry has put on hold Adani-owned Mumbai city airport's plan to shift a third of international flights to the new facility outside the city. The pause gives airlines and the operator more time to reach a consensus on managing traffic when the existing terminal undergoes rebuilding next year.

Mumbai International Airport Ltd (MIAL), a joint venture between Adani Airport Holdings Ltd and the Airports Authority of India, had proposed that 46 airlines move 265 of their 770 weekly international flights to Navi Mumbai Airport starting 25 October. Although most airlines disagreed, they were given until 4 pm on 6 October to submit the list of flights to be moved to the second Adani-owned airport.

However, during a 90-minute meeting on Tuesday afternoon chaired by civil aviation secretary Samir Kumar Sinha, airline representatives, the International Air Transport Association (IATA), Adani Airport executives and other stakeholders agreed to pause the flight relocation plan, according to two executives.

"The stakeholder concerns and the final agreed solution will have to be submitted along with Adani Airport's request to the ministry of civil aviation for approval of its major development plan (MDP) for the redevelopment of Terminal 1," one of these executives told Mint. The MDP is still awaiting ministry approval.

The ministry has asked Adani Airport, a part of Adani Enterprises Ltd, to meet again with all parties involved and create a transition plan that everyone agrees on, according to the second



Adani Airport must submit a consensus plan with airlines and other stakeholders to the ministry after 13 October.

executive. Adani Airport must revert to the ministry with a plan approved by all parties, including airlines, after 13 October. A notice from the office of Mumbai airport's chief airport officer, seen by Mint, said the meeting would

International Airport (NMIA), about 50 km away, the second person said. Both airports are managed by Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL). Adani Airport and the civil aviation ministry did not respond to Mint's query.

AIRLINE PUSHBACK

IB rebuilding starts in Jan, with domestic flights moving to T2, international flights to Navi Mumbai

ADANI says the shift is temporary, and the flight timings will be restored after Terminal 1 is rebuilt

NAVI Mumbai offers incentives, including waived landing fees and cash vouchers, to offset charges

AIRLINES and IATA say deadlines are too tight, while Adani readies transport and ground services

talk about the "next steps" following Tuesday's meeting.

The ministry also told the operator to get the required official approvals before starting the redevelopment or moving any flights to Navi Mumbai

ries emailed on Tuesday evening. MIAL plans to start rebuilding Terminal 1B in January 2027. Under the plan, domestic flights from Terminal 1 would move to Terminal 2, and some of Mumbai's international flights would

move to NMIA. Airlines support the rebuilding but disagree with the cut in international flights. The Airline Operators Committee - Mumbai has questioned the technical and practical reasons for the 33% reduction. It has asked for detailed studies on capacity, demand, and planned improvements at Terminal 2. Airlines say their support for rebuilding Terminal 1 should not be seen as an agreement to remove or move international flight times already planned for the winter schedule.

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Adani Airport says the move is temporary and necessary for rebuilding, and it will bring back old flight times with extra capacity once the new terminal opens. It says about 91% of passenger traffic will stay the same, with around five million passengers, or 9% of annual traffic, temporarily moved.

The rebuilt Terminal 1 is expected to handle 20 million passengers a year, one third more than it does now. Mumbai airport handled about 38 million domestic and more than 16 million international passengers in FY26.

To make the move easier, NMIA is waiving landing fees for new international flights. It also plans to give cash vouchers to cover the difference in user fees between the two airports.

Airlines say these offers do not solve their main concern: the cut in international flights and the reasons for moving flights.

At Tuesday's meeting, Adani Airport explained its preparations at Navi Mumbai, including transport connections and food services. One ground handler is already working, and talks with a second are ongoing. However, airlines and IATA told the ministry that the current deadlines were too tight to meet, the people present said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

HC: Google-Adani data centre work can continue at own risk

Krishna Yadav & Yadukrishna CS
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

The Andhra Pradesh high court (HC) on Tuesday cautioned that any work on or investment in the \$15-billion Google-Adani data centre in Visakhapatnam would be at the developer's own risk and cost pending the court's consideration of environmental concerns.

The bench of Chief Justice Lisa Gill allowed Vizag Hyperscale Data Center Park Ltd, an Adani Infra-owned special purpose vehicle set up to build the Google-Adani data centre project, to continue work on the facility, but made it clear that the company could not rely on investments made during the pendency of the case if the final decision goes against the project.

"The project in question may be continued by respondent No. 15 (Vizag Hyperscale Data Center Park Ltd) at its own risk and cost, and subject to the decision of this petition. Any investment, etc., which may be made, shall not vest in any equities in respondent No. 15 in case of a decision," the court remarked.

The high court took note of a previous assurance from the Andhra Pradesh government that due care and caution would be exercised to ensure that all steps relating to the project remained within the parameters of law, and that environmental protection was taken into account.

The court's observation effectively means that the company cannot later argue that investments made or work carried out during the litigation should protect the



The petitioner argued that a large-scale data centre warrants more stringent environmental scrutiny. REUTERS

project from an adverse order.

According to submissions made before the court, work on the site is currently at the stage of demolition, levelling, tree cutting and construction of a boundary wall.

The court was hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) filed by environment activist Bolisetty Satyanarayana, who sought a status quo on the project, citing alleged gaps in environmental permissions and challenging approvals related to the proposed data centre.

The petitioner has raised concerns over the project's environmental impact, its proximity to a protected area and the use of land belonging to the Simhachalam temple land within weeks.

The petitioner also raised concerns about the project's proximity to the Kambalakonda Wildlife Sanctuary, arguing that the site is around 0.86 km from the protected area and that the project, therefore, required greater environmental scrutiny.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

The PIL raises environmental concerns, including alleged gaps in approvals and the project's potential impact

Jio Platforms eyes \$114 billion valuation in India's biggest IPO

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Jio Platforms Ltd. is likely to seek a valuation of about 11 trillion rupees (\$114 billion) in its planned initial public offering, according to people familiar with the matter, falling short of earlier expectations for what may still be the country's largest-ever listing.

The telecom and digital services arm of Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries Ltd. has finished gauging demand for the offering and is likely to begin meetings with potential investors this week to discuss valuation and pricing, the people said, asking not to be identified because the information is private.

India's largest wireless operator is looking to open its IPO the week of 19 October and list before 30 October, the people said. Deliberations are ongoing and final dates, valuation and other details could change, they said. A representative for Jio didn't respond to a request for comments.

The valuation would also make Jio India's third most



Jio Platforms is planning to list by 30 October. MINT

valuable publicly traded company, behind parent Reliance, which has a market capitalization of about \$169 billion. Bharti Airtel Ltd., Jio's main telecommunications rival, is valued at about \$116 billion.

Jio filed its draft prospectus in June for an offering of 270 million new shares, equivalent to about 2.93% of its post-issue equity capital, according to Bloomberg calculations. Valuation figures floated earlier were higher, including in the \$130 billion to \$170 billion range at one point.

But a stock rout has dented

the pricing ambition of several IPOs in the country, including the marquee offering of the National Stock Exchange of India Ltd, which was forced to downsize its deal. In June, local brokerage Motilal Oswal Financial Services estimated Jio's valuation at between \$115 billion and \$118 billion, while Dolat Capital valued the company at around \$110 billion.

At a \$114 billion valuation, the Jio shares being offered would be worth about \$3.4 billion, still surpassing the 278.7 billion rupees (\$2.9 billion) raised by Hyundai Motor Co.'s Indian unit in 2024.

Jio's offering adds to an already busy year for India's IPO market. Listing proceeds surpassed \$9 billion in the July-September quarter, the most ever for the period, according to data compiled by Bloomberg. That pushed fundraising so far this year to more than \$13 billion.

Jio has appointed 19 banks to work on the IPO, including Kotak Mahindra Capital Co., Morgan Stanley, BofA Securities Inc., Axis Capital Ltd, BNP Paribas and Citigroup Inc.

Monster, PepsiCo, Campa get HC relief

Yash Tiwari & Neethi Lisa Rojan
MUMBAI

Three consumer firms—Monster Energy, PepsiCo and Reliance Consumer Products—secured stay orders from Delhi High Court on Tuesday against the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) orders restricting the use of the term 'energy drink' for products.

The relief came as the HC was hearing different pleas filed by the companies challenging the FSSAI orders passed in June and July. The regulator had directed manufacturers to stop using the 'energy drink' descriptor on certain caffeinated drinks and warned of enforcement action.

In a post on a social media on 1 July, FSSAI said it "issued notices to several beverage brands claiming to be 'energy drinks' for misbranding and misleading claims."

FSSAI also named brands, including Red Bull Energy Drink, PepsiCo India's Adrenaline Rush Energy Drink, Sting Energy Drink, Monster Energy, Hell-Energy Drink, and Reliance's Campa Energy Drink—Gold Boost, for using the descriptor 'energy drink'



FSSAI had ordered brands to stop using the term on caffeinated beverages, citing misbranding and misleading claims. MINT

on physical packaging and across-commerce platforms.

FSSAI said its food category system is not intended for product naming or labelling. It also said claims such as 'stimulates mind', 'energises body', 'enhances focus', 'boosts energy levels' and 'aids in general weakness' were not permissible unless legally supported.

Counsel appearing for Monster Energy argued that their products had been licensed under the relevant food cate-

gories and that FSSAI itself had earlier clarified that the term 'energy drink' was permitted for products falling within those categories. He said the decision taken by FSSAI did not allow the firm to respond to the notices which were served.

The Delhi High Court on 29 September set aside the notice served to Red Bull over 'energy drink' labelling, holding that the company should have been given an opportunity to respond before the regulator passed the order.

Existing 'energy drink' stocks can be sold, but no fresh production with the label is allowed, the high court clarified

Automobile dealers warn price hike could temper GST-led sales boom

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Automobile dealers are warning carmakers that price hikes could wipe out the benefit of last year's goods and services tax (GST) cut, potentially slowing the sales momentum seen across the industry just as it enters the festive season.

Price hikes and potential rate hikes by the Reserve Bank of India will shape the outlook in the coming months, Sai Giridhar, president of the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (Fada), told Mint.

"The silver lining out here is that, apart from the price

hikes, there are consumer offer schemes. Because in the last year, when there were price reductions, the consumer offers were practically eroded," he said. The entire ecosystem is built around keeping prices affordable. If consumers perceive affordability slipping, the industry will feel the impact, he added.

Girdhar's comments come after a warning by the largest dealers' grouping in its monthly sales note about price hikes. Fada wrote in its 6 October note that one year on from GST 2.0, affordability remains the single engine of this cycle, and dealers now flag further price increases eroding that very affordability as their fore-



More price hikes are likely, with Tata Motors PV saying only part of the cost increase was passed on to consumers so far. BLOOMBERG

most risk for the quarter ahead. "Protecting the GST gain is, to our mind, the key to converting the festive season into durable growth."

Even analysts have begun to caution about the potential impact of price hikes. "The key downside risks (to sales) are moderation in rural demand,

as certain states are logging a rainfall deficit, and demand impact due to price increases that are being implemented across categories," analysts at NuVama Institutional Equities wrote in a 9 September note.

The note of caution follows a period of robust sales since the start of FY27. Fada data released on 6 October showed vehicle retail sales in the first half of FY27 rose 20.77% year-on-year to 15.51 million units. Passenger vehicle sales rose 24.48% to 2.54 million

DEMAND PRESSURE

CARMAKERS have repeatedly raised prices this year amid sustained cost and margin pressures

RURAL demand and RBI rate hikes pose additional risks to sales, analysts and dealers said

units, while two-wheeler sales grew 20.43% to 11.04 million. Commercial vehicle sales increased 21.48% to 585,217 units. Carmakers have raised prices multiple times this year amid sustained cost pressures. Maruti Suzuki India increased prices three times, in June and August by up to ₹30,000 each time, followed by a hike of up to ₹20,000 on select models in September.

Hyundai Motor India raised prices thrice, by about 0.6% in January, up to ₹12,800 from

June and up to 1% from September. Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles also raised prices thrice, by a weighted average 0.5% for internal combustion engine (ICE) models in April, up to 1.5% across its portfolio in July and by up to ₹25,000 in September.

Mahindra raised prices by up to 2.5% in April and by an average 2.7% for sports utility vehicles (SUVs) in July.

Two-wheeler makers have also raised prices this year. Hero MotoCorp has implemented a cumulative blended average price hike of about 4.5% across its ICE portfolio since late February.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

McDonald's supplier HyFun eyes \$208 mn India IPO

Reuters
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HyFun Foods, the supplier for McDonald's and KFC, plans to raise up to ₹2,000 crore (\$207.7 million) in an IPO by late 2028, the frozen-foods maker's CEO said, betting on rising demand from restaurants, retailers and quick-delivery platforms.

The Indian firm expects to start preparations for the initial public offering in mid-2027, Haresh Karamchandani said in an interview. The IPO, composed of new shares, will fund expansion as it ramps up capacity and sharpens its focus on the domestic market.

Frozen foods such as French fries, pizzas and dumplings are gaining ground in India as consumers seek convenience amid quick-commerce boom. Households in the most populous country have traditionally preferred freshly cooked meal instead of ready-to-eat ones.

"The industry is at the cusp of a shift from fresh to frozen," Karamchandani said.

For HyFun, exports to more than 40 countries account for about three-fourths of its revenue, but he expects that share to fall to about half within five years as local demand rises.

India's food services industry is expected to grow to \$150 billion by the end of the decade from about \$90 billion, aided by the expansion of restaurant chains, according to Redseer Strategy Consultants.

HyFun expects its revenue to more than double to nearly ₹3,500 crore by FY28, led by capacity growth from regional restaurant chains and hotels as well as retail demand. Global restaurant chains contribute about 40% of HyFun's domestic revenue, but that share is expected to fall to around 30% over the next two years.

Passenger vehicle sales rose 32% in Sep: Dealers' body

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Passenger vehicle retail sales in India rose a robust 32.1% year-on-year to 4,27,213 units in September even as the total automobile retail sales for the month were 25,36,920 units, registering a growth of 31.82% over September 2025, Federation of Indian Automobile Dealers (Fada) said on Tuesday.

Two-wheelers' demand for the previous month recorded a 33.08% at 17,90,188 units against 13,45,153 units in September 2025, while three-wheelers sales stood at 1,32,570 units, up 22.25% from 1,08,444 units in the year-ago period.

At the same time, commercial vehicle sales grew 37.62% year-on-year in September 2026 at 1,03,557 units, Fada said in a statement.

"September '26 was the best-ever September in Indian auto retail, with the industry registering 25,36,920 units, up 31.82% year-on-year, which is the most base distorted print of the year—a mirror of last September, when buyers deferred purchases in the week before GST 2.0 took effect on September 22, 2025," said Sai Giridhar, president, Fada.

It was the best-ever September across five of the Fada's six categories and, with it, the best-ever first half of any financial year at 1,55,12,319 units (+20.77%), he said, adding that retail rose 4.69% over August; and even setting the distorted September aside, FY27's first five months grew about 17%,



PV sales rose 2.1% y-o-y in September. BLOOMBERG

which is the truer underlying run-rate.

Passenger vehicle retails were the best-ever September sales with urban and rural growing (markets) almost in lockstep at 32.11% and -32.09% YoY, respectively, Fada said.

The fuel mix offered the month's most watched signal: after alternative fuels overtook petrol for the first time in

Passenger vehicle retails were the best-ever September sales with urban and rural growing almost in lockstep

August, September saw the two settle into a near dead-heat, with petrol nudging marginally back ahead at 41.27% against alternative fuels' 41% (CNG at 23.11%, hybrid 9.44%, EV 8.45%), it said. The August crossover was therefore an inflection, not a decisive flip with petrol and alternative fuels now effectively at parity, trading the lead month to month, even as EV share rose to a fresh high and CNG eased, Fada said that overall, the outlook for October appears "cautiously optimistic".

Dealers warn hike may hit GST-led sales boom >P8

Netherlands backs Tata Steel, calls for cleaner steelmaking

The country aims to reach a final, tailor-made agreement with Tata no later than 1 Mar 2027

Dipali Banka & Nehal Chaliawala
MUMBAI

The Netherlands wants to retain steelmaking within its borders, but Tata Steel's operations must become cleaner, a spokesperson for the Dutch Minister of Climate and Green Growth said in an email in response to *Mint*'s queries.

Tata Steel's transition to a greener future remained important for the Netherlands, said Femmy Barends, the spokesperson cited above.

A domestic steel industry was important not only for the Dutch economy but also for reducing the nation's dependence on other countries. However, it must become cleaner and its impact on health and the environment "must be improved", she said.

The country aims to reach a final, tailor-made agreement with Tata Steel no later than 1 March 2027, Barends said. "We are not going to get ahead of ourselves at this stage. Nor can we give any guarantees."

For Tata Steel, the outcome of the Dutch negotiations will determine the economics and timeline of one of its largest decarbonization projects, while for the Netherlands, the talks are about retaining a strategic domestic steel industry without compromising on health and environmental standards.

Tata Steel, which runs the country's only primary steel plant at IJmuiden in North Holland, has been in negotiations with the country's government for over two years for financial aid to transition the factory's operations from coal-fired blast furnaces to electric arc furnaces.

However, with the two parties unable to reach an agreeable position by the end of September, they extended the deadline for their negotiations by five months to 1 March 2027. They said the



A domestic steel industry was important for the Dutch economy. MINT

extra time was needed as the two parties worked through regulatory, financial and operational challenges.

A spokesperson for Tata Steel said that one aspect of the negotiation was the finalization of the timeline and options

The business case for green steel, which is made in electric arc furnaces powered by renewable power, was also impacted by ongoing discussions on network tariffs, the recent revision by the European Commission of the time-

GOING GREEN

TATA Steel will have to spend €4 billion to €6.5 billion to cut emissions in Netherlands

REMAINING funds will come from firm's cash flows, debt and from parent company Tata Steel

IT had claimed that without govt aid, buying equipment to cut emissions did not make sense

TATA to get €2 bn from Netherlands government to transition to lower emissions

for a safe, responsible, and controlled closure of the company's coke and gas plants at IJmuiden. Another aspect was regulatory certainty and clarity for a solution for steel slag, which is inevitably generated during steel production.

table for the phase-out of free CO allowances, and the prioritization and sequencing of the capital spend, the spokesperson said in an email.

"Tata Steel Nederland remains committed to a realistic approach to the inte-



Elevenlabs is open to making acquisitions in India. ISTOCKPHOTO

AI voice firm ElevenLabs to make big investment in India

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

London-based AI voice company ElevenLabs plans to invest "hundreds of millions of dollars" in India, its co-founder Mati Staniszewski told *Reuters* on Tuesday.

Global AI firms have deepened their India bets over the past year, with OpenAI and Anthropic opening their first India offices and expanding local partnerships.

The push coincides with multibillion-dollar commitments from Amazon, Microsoft and Google to build AI, cloud and data center infrastructure in a market increasingly viewed as critical to global AI growth.

Nvidia-backed Elevenlabs, which doubled its valuation from February to \$22 billion in September, is open to making acquisitions in India, Staniszewski added, but declined to disclose any names.

Founded in 2022, ElevenLabs' AI voice technology can convert text into speech and perform tasks such as processing refunds, renewing insurance policies and booking appointments.

Its customers in India include edtech company PhysicsWallah, electrical equipment maker Havells and fintech Razorpay.

The investment would be used to add local teams, develop models and work on Indian languages. The company declined to mention the exact investment amount. *CNBC TV18* first reported the development.

The company also said that it would partner with the southern state of Karnataka to use voice AI to make government services more accessible to citizens and AI-powered voice restoration to support people without the ability to speak.

Besides Nvidia, its backers include Wellington, T. Rowe Price, Andreessen Horowitz, Lightspeed, EQT and Goldman Sachs.

Karthik Rajaram, general manager and country leader for India, said Elevenlabs has worked with 250 enterprises in the region, with 100 million annual AI-agent conversations across 14 Indian languages, a rapidly growing developer ecosystem, and an expanding library of Indian voices driving adoption. "So what's striking is that it is not just only the size of the opportunity that we have in the country. It is the sheer breadth and complexity of the market that we have."

Sebi fund swells, spending barely moves

FROM PAGE 1

funds in the country "have been on the agenda of late in the government's highest offices and have seen inter-ministerial memos seeking a possible strategy on whether the funds are not very well aligned with ground realities or need some kind of a strategic overhaul," a senior official with direct knowledge of the developments told *Mint*, requesting anonymity.

Mint's emails to the finance ministry (which oversees the market regulator), the ministry of electronics and information technology (the nodal cyber security entity), the Prime Minister's Office and Sebi did not receive a response until publishing time.

The underutilization comes amid rising risks of cyber frauds, digital arrests and finfluencers, which have taken centre stage in the Indian markets. Sebi's 2025 survey, covering 91,950 households across urban and rural India, found that 62% of investors make some or most investment decisions based on finfluencer recommendations. Sebi said in its annual report for FY26 that many such influencers operate

Underused corpus

The Securities and Exchange Board of India spent only 0.4% of the fund's total corpus in FY26.

Details of Sebi's Investor Protection and Education Fund

	Total funds (in ₹ crore)	% of funds used
2022-23	244.8	1.88
2023-24	563.6	5.39
2024-25	764.2	0.35
2025-26	969.8	0.48

Source: Sebi annual reports

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

without accountability or verified performance data.

The regulator's biggest expense was investor education—₹2.26 crore in FY26. The rest was spent on seminars, financial literacy, committee meetings and "others." Sebi's annual report did not specify what "others" refers to.

IPEF utilization has varied sharply over the years. Spending peaked at ₹30.4 crore in FY24, when Sebi used 5.4% of the funds available. It added ₹208.3 crore worth of funds to

IPEF in FY26.

A second official who also requested anonymity said that since then, investor protection funds and the government's role have been discussed many times—at ministries including the finance ministry and the ministry of electronics and information technology and collaboratively with industry stakeholders. *Mint* could not independently determine if Sebi was a part of these discussions.

The IPEF regulations give Sebi a wide mandate for using

the fund. It can be spent on investor education through seminars, training, research and publications as well as awareness programmes through print and electronic media.

"Low utilization may mean that money earmarked for investor education, legal assistance, awareness, investor protection and other permitted purposes is not reaching investors at the required scale. It can also raise questions about whether programme design, outreach and measurement are adequate," said Alay Razvi, managing partner at Accord Juris, a law firm.

"There may be a need to broaden and clearly specify the definition of investor protection from the government's end," said Deep Narayan Mukherjee, partner and director—risk management and data science—at BCG India. "This can lead to increased utilization of these funds in areas such as research and development for cybersecurity solutions against investor frauds in collaborations with universities."

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RPSG Group weighs 15-20% stake sale in IPL team LSG

FROM PAGE 1

realize value through a future exit," said Ketan Mukhija, partner and co-head for private equity and venture capital at Kochhar & Co., a corporate law firm.

LSG, which joined the IPL with the Gujarat Titans in 2022, is one of the few teams that is yet to reach the final of the tournament. After reaching the third position on the table in its first two years, its performance has declined, and it finished at the bottom in the latest edition that ended on 31 May.

"For a franchise such as LSG, on-field performance is one factor, but it is not the only determinant of value. Brand strength, fan base, commercial revenues, media and sponsorship economics, growth potential and the scarcity value of owning an IPL franchise can all support a strong valuation. The key for an investor is whether the price being paid is justified by these underlying fundamentals and leaves sufficient headroom for future value creation," Mukhija of Kochhar & Co. added.



LSG, which joined the IPL with the Gujarat Titans in 2022, is one of the few teams that is yet to reach the final of the tournament. PTI

Indian billionaires have already taken over two IPL teams this year. Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) was sold at a valuation of \$1.78 billion in March, while Rajasthan Royals changed hands at a valuation of \$1.63 billion.

Care Ratings said in a 10 September report on RPSG Sports that recent high-value IPL transactions have unlocked franchise valuations. The rating company also cited the expiry of the lock-in period for a stake sale in LSG as providing "significant financial

flexibility" to its owner.

RPSG Sports has a ₹709 crore annual franchise-fee obligation through FY31, according to Care. The rating company said RPSG Sports is expected to continue relying on promoter support and external debt to meet its obligations. RPSG Sports generated ₹499.3 crore in operating income in FY26, while its revenue stood at about ₹530 crore in H1 of FY27, including about ₹415 crore from central rights income.

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Trump's \$100,000 H-1B fee hits legal roadblock

FROM PAGE 1

government or non-profit bodies, would be unable to absorb the \$100,000 fee.

On 8 June, Judge Leo Sorokin struck down the fee entirely, stating that entry-restriction laws that the president relied on while passing the proclamation do not grant him taxing power. He added that while the president has broad immigration powers, he did not have the authority to impose a tax.

Trump had imposed the \$100,000 fee for new H-1B applications through a proclamation on 19 September 2025, citing misuse of the programme. It does not apply to

existing H-1B holders or renewals. On 18 September, he extended it by a year to 21 September 2027 without substantive changes.

The two court rulings gain significance as the US heads for mid-term polls next month.

"I doubt most Americans are aware of H-1B policies in particular, but know the President is hostile to just about every immigration pathway. Polls seem to show that the public has turned against the Administration on the issue of immigration," said Greg Siskind, co-founder of Siskind Susser Immigration Lawyers.

He added that for now, "the order is vacated, which means judges have said that the pol-

icy cannot be carried out until a trial where a judge can make a final decision. Judges have granted preliminary injunctions in these cases which means that the judge believed that the plaintiffs are likely to win at trial."

A second lawyer suggested that the Trump administration could appeal to a higher court.

"In the short term, Trump can appeal to the relevant appellate court for the court which issued the injunction. We can have instances of conflicting decisions, and the administration has demonstrated its willingness to push its agenda by any means possible," said Russell Stamets, partner at Circle of Counsel, a



The Trump administration has been clamping down on H-1B visa holders in the US, citing abuse of the visa. ISTOCKPHOTO

New Delhi-based law firm.

Siskind, who was co-counsel for the plaintiffs in the California case, said the administration could also approach

the US Supreme Court. He advised employers to insulate themselves by "starting the process early, counseling workers to not leave the US

after arrival unless absolutely necessary, staying abreast of changes."

Around 57,000 new H-1B visas were approved for Indians last year, down 28% from FY24. Last fiscal year, Indians received about half of the total new H-1B approvals. The US government follows an October-September financial calendar. Trump's clampdown on H-1B visa holders has forced home-grown tech services companies to send fewer people on

H-1B visas, according to a *Mint* report on 25 May.

This labour tightening is expected to have implications for the country's \$300 billion tech sector as the US is their biggest market, accounting for at least a third to about half of its revenue.

The country's largest tech services firms, including Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, Infosys Ltd, and Cognizant Technology Solutions Corp, send executives to the US on H-1B visas to work with clients and are amongst

the top 10 beneficiaries of such visas.

For now, this issue comes after the Trump administration has been clamping down on H-1B visa holders in the US, citing abuse of the visa.

Pressure is also building in Congress, where Republican lawmakers have filed at least four bills this year to curb the programme. Marjorie Taylor Greene's 'End H-1B Now Act' on 2 January and Greg Steube's EXILE Act on 9 February seek to end it. Eli Crane's 'End H-1B Visa Abuse Act of 2026' introduced on 22 April, would pause new visas, and Chip Roy's bill on 4 June would cut the maximum stay to two years from six.



FMCG demand holds up in Q2, margins under pressure

Price hikes loom as rising input costs and inflation threaten earnings; volumes stay resilient

Neethi Lisa Rojan
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MUMBAI

Indian consumer companies are seeing demand hold up in the September quarter, but investors are watching margins, underlying consumption and rural demand as input costs remain a concern.

Early quarterly updates point to continued growth across consumer businesses, although a later festive calendar is expected to shift a significant part of demand into the December quarter. This comes as India's headline inflation rate (CPI) rose to 4.82% in August 2026, the highest since December 2024, from 4.45% in the previous month.

"Amid sustained inflationary pressure, the need for price hikes is rising, potentially impacting volumes ahead," said analysts at HDFC Securities in a 5 October report. "As companies attempt to balance growth and margins, we expect earnings stress to persist."

For Marico, the maker of Parachute and Saffola, domestic underlying volume growth reached double digits in the September quarter.

"Domestic demand remained resilient during the quarter, even as the operating environment stayed volatile through the period," the firm said in a quarterly filing on Monday.

Marico's value-added hair oils business recorded growth in the twenties for the sixth consecutive quarter, while volumes of Saffola oils declined as the company prioritised profitability and reduced supplies of some variants.

Copra prices remained about 35% below their peak, supporting Marico's gross margins. "We forecast volumes to grow -10% YoY led by Parachute, where volumes are likely to grow -14% yoy—21-quarter high (-10% yoy in Q1 FY27), reflecting a second consecutive quarter of market share gain in our



India's headline inflation rose to 4.82% in August, the highest since December 2024, increasing pressure on companies to raise prices. BLOOMBERG

view," analysts at Nuvama Institutional Equities said in a report on Tuesday.

AWL Agri Business is seeing a broad-based expansion beyond its traditional edible oils business. The company delivered 12% year-on-year volume growth and 24% revenue growth dur-

ing the quarter. Food and FMCG revenue rose 33%, crossing ₹2,000 crore for the first time in a quarter. The traditional edible-oil business was more subdued, with volumes growing 3%.

Cost environment will be another variable. Godrej Consumer Products Ltd said it would report "high-teens

COSTS CLOUD OUTLOOK			
AWL Agri Business volume was up 12% and revenue 24%; food and FMCG revenue rose 33%	MARICO has seen double-digit volume growth, led by its value-added hair oils business in Q2	GODREJ Consumer Products and Dabur flagged rising raw material costs and margin pressure	V2 Retail reported just 0.5% same-store sales growth, while DMart's revenue was at ₹19,206 crore

responding through a combination of calibrated pricing actions, cost-saving initiatives, supply-chain efficiencies, and disciplined cost management."

Dabur also flagged pressure on margin. "Operating margins were impacted by inflationary pressures during the quarter; partly offset by calibrated price

increases and ongoing cost-saving initiatives," Dabur said in its quarterly update on Tuesday. It expects revenues to record double-digit growth in Q2.

Sugar prices also corrected sharply, down 21% from the peak, after a sharp 16% run-up in August. Brent crude prices also hovered around \$100 a barrel due to geopolitical uncertainties, driving higher packaging costs across consumer companies and increasing raw material costs for detergent makers.

Nykaa offers a different picture, with both its beauty and fashion businesses growing at a rapid pace. Nykaa's like-for-like store sales growth was the strongest in six quarters.

Value retailers had a tougher time. V2 Retail, the value-fashion retailer, reported 0.5% same-store sales growth because Navratri and Durga Puja fell in the September quarter last year and will fall in October this year, it said.

The timing difference is important for retailers. "With the festivals ahead, we are well-positioned to capture the demand uplift in Q3 while sustaining our long-term growth," V2 Retail said.

The seasonal change also matters for DMart operator Avenue Supermarkets. It reported standalone operating revenue of ₹19,206 crore in September quarter. Investors were unimpressed. V2's share price fell 19% to hit a 52-week low after the update, while shares of DMart slipped 4% on Monday.

The inherent challenges of listed players become visible in such instances. "We are not very bullish about listed large players and in all of these consumption categories. The future is going to be around the smaller players who will innovate more, who will spend more on new products, who will come out with more experiences," said Anand Ramanathan, partner and consumer industry leader, Deloitte India.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

L&T Realty seeks to double portfolio to 150 mn sq. ft by '31

Madhurima Nandy
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BENGALURU

L&T Realty, the real estate arm of conglomerate Larsen & Toubro Ltd, aims to double its portfolio to roughly 150 million sq. ft by 2031, focusing on premium and luxury residential projects to drive faster growth, managing director and chief executive Anupam Kumar told *Mint*.

Under its business plan, the company intends to expand its portfolio from 70-71 million sq. ft in 2025-26 to about 150 million sq. ft over the next five years. Residential-led developments will comprise about 85% of this total, with commercial projects making up the remaining 15%.

"This is not growth for the sake of scale. It is a calibrated expansion anchored in our existing strengths across Mumbai, NCR (National Capital Region), Bengaluru and Chennai, with selective land positions in future growth corridors as they open up. Our philosophy remains clear: a fewer, bigger, stronger — not indiscriminate expansion across geographies," said Kumar. "We are deliberately selective about land and will walk away from opportunities that do not meet our return threshold," he added.

A veteran of the Larsen & Toubro group for over three decades, Kumar previously led the minerals and metals vertical before transitioning to the real estate business in 2022 and assuming leadership of the division in late 2023.

The real estate company's growth model rests on four pillars, Kumar said: land and redevelopment opportunities,

differentiated premium and luxury products, technology-led execution, and a customer-centric sales engine.

"Our engineering heritage gives us a structural advantage in delivering large and complex developments. We are also investing in technology, including a single artificial intelligence (AI) command centre that integrates design, cost, sales, CRM, financial modelling, competitive tracking and forecasting," he added.

The Mumbai firm has a strong, phased residential launch pipeline for FY27, with three to four launches planned in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), two in Delhi-NCR and two in Bengaluru, Kumar said. He added that most of these launches are scheduled from October onward, and that Gurugram, Bengaluru and Mumbai will have a combined launch potential of ₹25,000 crore.

"Our objective is to maintain at least 12 quarters of ready-to-launch visibility while retaining the flexibility to respond to evolving market conditions and customer demand," Kumar said.



L&T Realty plans seven to eight residential launches in FY27, says managing director and chief executive Anupam Kumar. MINT

India's real estate sector, particularly the residential market, has experienced a multi-year surge since the pandemic. L&T Realty's growth push comes as fellow corporate developers including Birla Estates, Adani Properties, and Raymond Realty are also scaling up operations. Property consultants note that homebuyers today prioritize trusted brands, placing greater reliance on developers with strong credibility and proven execution track records.

Housing demand across the top eight cities held steady in the July-September quarter, with sales touching 123,000 units, a 1% uptick from the previous quarter, according to Liases Foras Research estimates. Developers, however, are bringing fresh supply to market faster than demand is expanding, with new project launches rising 7.6% quarter-on-quarter to 113,391 units.

"Real estate is inherently a cyclical segment, and we do not build our strategy on the assumption that every year will mirror the last. Our five-year plan is not a short-term response to a strong market; our focus now is to build a business that can perform across cycles," added Kumar. For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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A quiz on the week's development.





Francis Halzen's work was instrumental to the construction of the IceCube Neutrino Observatory in Antarctica. AFP

Halzen wins Nobel prize in physics for ghost particles

AP
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Francis Halzen won the Nobel Prize in physics on Tuesday for his efforts to demystify a rare group of neutrinos, tiny cosmic particles that scientists believe offer clues to how the universe evolved.

"It was a great surprise and I obviously didn't expect it," Halzen said, speaking to the committee by phone from Italy, in a call broadcast at the news conference to announce the winner.

Halzen said it was predicted before that he would win the Nobel Prize but the announcement still made him feel "strange."

"I am working on a proposal, and I hope that this prize will help getting it approved," he said to chuckles from the audience.

The Nobel Committee for Physics also said Halzen's work was instrumental to the construction of the IceCube Neutrino Observatory in Antarctica.

"Francis Halzen realized that the ice at the South Pole could visualize these neutrino messengers from cosmos," committee member Eva Olsson said during the news conference. "People joined him in the quest for these neutrino messengers. The messenger is bringing information from cosmos. They opened the door to distant galaxies and tell us about the processes of exploding stars."

Born in Belgium, the 82-year-old scientist is affiliated with the University of Wisconsin-Madison in the US, which operates the IceCube Neutrino Observatory.

Neutrinos are tiny cosmic particles with a mind-bogglingly small mass. Yet they are everywhere: they spew from stars like the sun and trillions zip through our bodies every second.

Scientists can't glimpse the mysterious ghost particles zooming around on their own. Instead, they measure what happens when the tiny particles collide with other bits of matter, producing flashes of

light or charged particles.

Halzen helped pull the curtain back on a rare gang of neutrinos that scientists consider messengers from the cosmos, offering clues to how the universe evolved.

"This experiment in the Antarctic is a revolutionary way of understanding the universe that we didn't have before," said Michael Moloney, chief executive officer for the American Institute of Physics.

In a post on social media, Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever sent his "sincere congratulations" to Halzen, who he said is the 11th Belgian to win a Nobel prize.

De Wever called the award "impressive recognition for a lifetime dedicated to shedding light on the great mysteries of the cosmos through its smallest components."

A representative from the IceCube Neutrino Observatory did not respond.

Ellen Moons, secretary-general of the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences, announced the award Tuesday in Stockholm. She is the first woman to head the prestigious academy and present the award.

The prize money this year is 12 million Swedish kronor (about \$1.2 million), whether for an individual, a small group of laureates or an organization.

Last year, three scientists won the Nobel Prize in physics for research on the strange behaviour of subatomic particles called quantum tunneling that enabled the ultrasensitive measurements achieved by MRI machines and laid the groundwork for better cell phones and faster computers.

The announcements of this year's prizes began Monday with the Nobel Prize in medicine being awarded to three scientists whose work led to a tool that uses light to help unravel how the brain works.

This week's awards continue Wednesday with the chemistry prize and literature on Thursday. After Friday's peace prize is awarded, the Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences will be announced on Monday.

Al-Maliki said coalition naval forces destroyed weapons depots and warehouses containing explosive-laden boats and naval mines in Yemen's Hodeidah province to prevent the Houthis from targeting vessels in the strait and the Red Sea.

In response, the Houthis launched missile and drone attacks

against multiple targets in Saudi Arabia, including King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh, an Aramco refinery in Rabigh, and multiple Saudi military installations, said Houthi military spokesman Yahya Sare'e. He warned commercial air carriers that "Saudi airspace has now become a theater for our operations."

Saudi-led forces have conducted 60 airstrikes and mis-

sile attacks against Houthi-held San'a, Yemen's capital, and other targets since launching the offensive, Sare'e said.

Since taking the city last month, the Houthis have attacked Saudi energy facilities and threatened Saudi ship traffic through the 18-mile wide entrance to the Red Sea, raising concerns in Riyadh, Europe and Washington about further disruptions to regional oil supplies.

Col. Majid al-Nuzaili, a Yemeni military spokesman, said the operation included pro-government forces known as the Giants Brigades and had succeeded in gaining control over the strait, but that claim couldn't be separately confirmed.

The escalating fighting in Yemen, the worst in the country in years, shows how the Iran war is fueling instability throughout the Middle East

Bloomberg
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Paramount Skydance Corp. closed its \$110 billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery Inc. on Tuesday, completing one of the biggest media mergers of all time after engaging in a bruising battle for control with Netflix Inc. and fending off antitrust lawsuits.

The new company, which will be called Skydance, combines two of the five largest Hollywood film studios, uniting the homes of major franchises such as *Harry Potter* and *Mission Impossible*. It will now be home to dozens of TV networks, from CBS to TNT, and two major subscription streaming services, Paramount+ and HBO Max.

David Ellison, who only completed the merger of his Skydance Media film production company with Paramount in August 2025, has continued to consolidate power in the media industry and has become one of Hollywood's biggest moguls. Still, he brought in Ynon Kreiz from Mattel Inc. to share oversight of Skydance as co-chief executive officer. Kreiz will manage day-to-day operations while Ellison maintains the creative, big-picture vision and handles relationships with talent.

"Today is a historic day, not just for Skydance but for our entire industry," Ellison said in a statement.

After pulling off two mega-mergers of century-old Hollywood companies in just over a year, Ellison now faces the significant challenge of making it all work. That means eliminating overlapping businesses and jobs without fanning the ire of Hollywood, which is already suffering through a downturn and has opposed the consolidation from the start. Skydance also will need to manage nearly \$80 billion in debt while adhering to a strict calendar of theatrical releases as stipulated by the lawsuit settlement.

The path to closing the merger was often a rocky one and at times seemed



Paramount agreed to acquire Warner Bros. in February following a months-long bidding war against Netflix. REUTERS

likely to derail. But Ellison was determined to succeed, and saw the deal as essential to be able to compete with the likes of Netflix, the Walt Disney Co., Amazon.com Inc. and Apple Inc. "They're starting off at a great place," Michael J. Wolf, CEO of Acti-

The merged entity will also be home to dozens of TV networks as well as two major subscription streaming services

vate Strategy, said in an interview on Bloomberg TV Monday. "The logic makes sense. Scale puts them in the right position. Now they have to deliver against scale." Paramount agreed to acquire Warner Bros. in February following a months-long bidding war against Netflix, which had previously committed to purchasing Warner Bros.' studios and streaming business, but not the cable channels. Ellison clinched the deal by sweetening the offer price and bringing his father Larry Ellison in to personally guarantee funding. Paramount paid

a \$2.8 billion breakup fee to Netflix on behalf of Warner Bros. and argued it would be able to clinch a speedy closing of its own deal, promising to pay fees to Warner Bros. shareholders of \$7 million a day if the deal wasn't finalized by 30 September.

Though Paramount did manage to get quick antitrust approval from the US department of justice, the European Union and other key jurisdictions, it was delayed by a pair of lawsuits brought by 12 states and the Writers Guild of America, who were concerned about the threat of higher prices for consumers and fewer jobs. Thousands of actors, directors, writers and producers signed a letter protesting the deal.

Much of the fear stems from Paramount's pledge to extract more than \$6 billion in annual synergies within

three years of closing the merger. Gerry Cardinale, founder and managing partner of RedBird Capital Partners, a Paramount investor, said there are other ways to cut costs and operate more efficiently than simply reducing headcount. A company wouldn't spend billions of dollars a year making movies, "and figure your entire premise of your business plan is to fire everybody in Hollywood," Cardinale said at the Bloomberg Screentime conference in Los Angeles last week. "It's just the opposite."

Skydance's debt load will continue to weigh on the company, however. Its interest bills are much higher now than if it had issued debt just a few months earlier, since inflation concerns have lifted global borrowing costs. Paramount sold \$52 billion of loans and bonds in just a week, a tight timeline for any debt deal and particularly so for one of the largest financings in recent history.

As part of a negotiated settlement

with the states, whose case was led by California Attorney General Rob Bonta, Paramount vowed to release at least 30 films a year in theatres and keep them there exclusively for 45 days before making them available for viewing at home. The company also agreed to create an editorial independence board for its news organizations, CBS and CNN, an effort to address concerns that the Ellison family's friendliness with President Donald Trump would prompt them to try to influence the coverage.

Ellison has so far agreed to keep CBS and CNN separate and under different leadership. In announcing a new executive team on Monday, he said that CNN CEO Mark Thompson would remain in his role and Bari Weiss would keep her title as editor-in-chief of CBS News. While acknowledging "trepidations about this moment," Thompson said in a letter to staff that he has "real confidence" that the new Skydance leadership understands "and will fully support the principle and practice of the kind of independent news that CNN has always stood for."

Dana Goldberg, a longtime Skydance Media executive who developed and produced films including *Top Gun: Maverick* and several *Mission: Impossible* entries, and Josh Greenstein, a previous president of Sony Pictures' Motion Picture Group where he oversaw films and franchises including *Spider-Man*, will jointly oversee the new Skydance Motion Picture Group. James Gunn and Peter Safran, the co-chiefs of DC Studios, the unit at Warner Bros. that controls comic-book characters including Batman, Superman and Wonder Woman, will continue their roles at Skydance.

One executive who won't be part of the new team at Skydance is David Zaslav, the president and CEO of Warner Bros., who will take his leave along with potentially more than \$667 million in cash severance and stock awards triggered by the sale.

Anthropic's Amodei made \$18 mn last year, middle of tech CEO pack

Reuters
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Dario Amodei made \$18 million last year as chief executive officer (CEO) of Claude AI developer Anthropic, the company's initial public offering (IPO) filling shows, putting him in the middle ranks of top executives at major technology firms in terms of compensation.

Anthropic is preparing for an IPO as early as this fall that could value it at more than \$2 trillion, according to its IPO prospectus seen by Reuters. Amodei's pay last year puts him above CEOs at Alphabet and Amazon, but behind those at Oracle and Nvidia.

Amodei's pay leans heavily towards stock and other sorts

of compensation, suggesting that like many other tech founders, his yearly salary will account for just a fraction of his wealth.

Dario Amodei and his sister, Anthropic president Daniela Amodei, each had their annual salaries doubled this past July to \$1.4 million. Stock and options awards made up the bulk of their packages in 2025, with Daniela Amodei receiving a total of \$16.4 million last year.

Chief financial officer Krishna Rao earned \$720,250 last year. He was granted options to buy 1.4 million shares when he was hired in 2024, and exercised options worth \$385,285 in 2025.

The rise in US CEO pay in recent years has far outpaced the gains for the average



Amodei's pay leans heavily towards stock and other sorts of compensation. AFP

worker, a dynamic critics worry could be exacerbated by artificial intelligence's (AI) widespread adoption.

Courtney Yu, director of research for executive compensation data firm Equilar,

said Amodei's \$18 million haul "seems on the lower end for a company valued at \$2 trillion, but it will be interesting to see how that changes once the company goes public" and his full ownership stake is shown.

With six other co-founders, Amodei may wind up getting a lesser share of the wealth created by the IPO compared with other major tech CEOs, Yu added.

Other giant companies pay less on a year-by-year basis, with executives benefiting from enormous stock ownership while having only salary and security costs reflected in annual filings. Yu

said the disclosures show how executives don't need to worry about year-by-year pay.

"Founder CEOs typically own enough equity that when the company does well and the stock prices increases they can just live off the wealth of the equity they already own, and typically don't take in a lot in annual compensation," Yu said.

Anthropic said in the filing it offered a mix of salary, equity awards and other benefits. The S-1 statement seen by Reuters does not describe the founders' share of ownership in the company, which could be worth billions

of dollars, depending on the final terms and valuation of the IPO.

The Amodei siblings and their fellow co-founders pledged in the IPO filing to dedicate 80% of their personal Anthropic equity to charitable causes.

Asked about the 80% figure Monday, an Anthropic spokesperson noted an essay Dario Amodei posted earlier this year, where he wrote that wealthy individuals have an obligation to help address problems stemming from AI adoption, and decreed that many wealthy people, particularly in the tech industry, "have recently adopted a cynical and nihilistic attitude that philanthropy is inevitably fraudulent or useless."

Saudi-backed forces launch fight to free Bab al-Mandeb from Houthis

David S. Cloud & Saleh Al-Batati

Ground operation is aimed at taking back the strategic port of Mokha, which the Iran-backed rebels have used to disrupt oil-tanker traffic.

Saudi and Yemeni forces pressed a counteroffensive against Houthi fighters Monday.

Officials said, seeking to oust the rebels from the strategic port city of Mokha and ease the threat to energy exports through the narrow Bab al-Mandeb Strait.

Around 100 jet fighters were providing air cover to Yemeni ground troops as they pushed north along the coast in a flanking move toward Mokha in a dawn operation, said Maj. Gen. Turki al-Maliki,

a spokesman for the Saudi-led military coalition in Yemen.

Al-Maliki said coalition naval forces destroyed weapons depots and warehouses containing explosive-laden boats and naval mines in Yemen's Hodeidah province to prevent the Houthis from targeting vessels in the strait and the Red Sea.

In response, the Houthis launched missile and drone attacks

against multiple targets in Saudi Arabia, including King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh, an Aramco refinery in Rabigh, and multiple Saudi military installations, said Houthi military spokesman Yahya Sare'e. He warned commercial air carriers that "Saudi airspace has now become a theater for our operations."

Saudi-led forces have conducted 60 airstrikes and mis-

sile attacks against Houthi-held San'a, Yemen's capital, and other targets since launching the offensive, Sare'e said.

Since taking the city last month, the Houthis have attacked Saudi energy facilities and threatened Saudi ship traffic through the 18-mile wide entrance to the Red Sea, raising concerns in Riyadh, Europe and Washington about further disruptions to regional oil supplies.

Col. Majid al-Nuzaili, a Yemeni military spokesman, said the operation included pro-government forces known as the Giants Brigades and had succeeded in gaining control over the strait, but that claim couldn't be separately confirmed.

The escalating fighting in Yemen, the worst in the country in years, shows how the Iran war is fueling instability throughout the Middle East



Yemeni military reinforcements travel along the coastal road between Aden and Mokha. AP

and heightening the risk to global energy flows after Tehran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz in March caused the worst oil-supply jolt in recent history.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio told reporters on Monday: "The Saudis have come under Houthi attack

and see the threat that that poses, and they have a right to defend themselves. And obviously the Yemeni forces are going to try to retake territory that they were ousted from."

The Houthis seized Mokha early last month, expanding their territory closer to the

narrowest parts of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait and threatening Saudi oil exports. The stepped-up attacks on Monday against Saudi Arabia underscored the Houthi willingness to escalate the conflict further, analysts said.

"They want to push back against their losses by striking Saudi to show they still have the capacity to disrupt the kingdom's economy," said Adam Baron, a fellow at the New America Foundation in Washington who specializes in Yemen and the Persian Gulf.

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman last month asked Trump for military help against the Houthis, but the president has limited the U.S.'s involvement to providing intelligence and other

indirect support, according to a U.S. military official.

For the U.S., opening another active military front against the Houthis risks overextending U.S. forces and deepening the risks to international shipping, analysts said.

The Houthis have largely avoided targeting American or international commercial ships in the region following a 2025 ceasefire with the U.S.

The Houthis are among a militia groups throughout the Middle East that receive weapons and training from Iran and its Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps as a part of Tehran's strategy to project power in the region. But they had remained largely on the sidelines of the war between

the U.S. and Iran until a ceasefire in Yemen unraveled in July.

The war began in 2014, when the Houthis swept into San'a. A Saudi-led coalition entered the war on behalf of Yemen's internationally recognized government in 2015. The conflict has killed more than 150,000 people, displaced millions and pushed the Arab world's poorest nation to the brink of famine.

"We will continue on the principle of reciprocity—escalation for escalation—to its ultimate end, until the Saudi regime stops its reckless interference with what remains of our lives. It will pay the price through its security and economy, and we will meet pain with pain," said Abdul-Malik al-Ajri, a senior Houthi official, wrote in a social-media post Monday.

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NEWS
NUMBERS

25%

THE JUMP in sales year-on-year reported by Titan for its consumer business in the second quarter, driven by demand for jewellery, watches and eyewear.

\$1 tn

ELON MUSK'S net worth on Monday, after a rally in SpaceX and Tesla shares restored the trillionaire status he first reached in June.

39,685

THE ELECTRICITY volume traded by the Indian Energy Exchange, in million units, during the second quarter of fiscal year 2027—a 12.7% year-on-year increase.

670

THE NUMBER of Chinese lenders that ceased to exist in 2025 as Beijing accelerated mergers and closures to consolidate a fragmented financial system, per Fitch.

4

THE NUMBER of new airports planned in West Bengal by 2028 under the UDAN scheme, at Purulia, Paschim Medinipur, Dakshin Dinajpur and Alipurduar.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Swara Baby gets nod for ₹1,000 crore IPO

Swara Baby Products, a contract manufacturer of baby diapers, adult diapers and feminine hygiene products backed by FirstCry, received Securities and Exchange Board of India's (Sebi) approval on Tuesday to proceed with its proposed ₹1,000 crore initial public offering (IPO).

The proposed IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares aggregating up to ₹500 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) valued at ₹500 crore by promoters, according to the draft red herring prospectus. The OFS includes the sale of shares worth up to ₹300 crore by Brainbees Solutions Ltd and up to ₹200 crore by Anadya Bon Merchari LLP. The company filed its preliminary IPO papers on 2 July with the Sebi and obtained the regulator's final observation on 6 October.

The funds will be used to pursue inorganic growth through acquisitions and for general corporate purposes.

PTI



The resolution credits Modi's 'decisive leadership' for securing peace and public trust.

PTI

Cabinet hails Modi's 25 years in govt

The Union Cabinet on Tuesday hailed PM Narendra Modi's 25 years of uninterrupted leadership as the head of government, first as the Gujarat chief minister and then as the Prime Minister, saying his "extraordinary journey" was guided by the principle of "nation first and citizen first".

In a resolution, the cabinet also said that three overwhelming mandates in Gujarat and support in three successive Lok Sabha elections reflect the "enduring trust" that the public has reposed in Prime Minister Modi.

Briefing reporters on the resolution, information and broadcasting minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the cabinet passed the resolution congratulating the prime minister on completing 25 years of continuous leadership as head of government.

Vaishnaw said ten salient features capture the unbroken thread connecting his leadership in Gujarat with his leadership later as the country's Prime Minister. The resolution also highlighted that Prime Minister Modi's faith in technology emerges through achievements in everyday services and scientific frontiers.

PTI

Govt to rework jet fuel price fund as airlines raise charges

The rethink comes as ATF prices for domestic airlines rise for the third month

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The government is reworking its ₹10,000-crore aviation turbine fuel (ATF) price-stabilization fund as jet-fuel prices surge again, with IndiGo raising fuel surcharges and airlines pressing for changes to the pricing process.

Civil aviation minister K. Ram Mohan Naidu told *Mint* on Tuesday that fresh work is underway on the price stabilization mechanism, two months after the original scheme failed to attract a single airline. "The scheme or a price stabilization fund is there. But airlines did not apply for it then. So we will see what can be reworked. We are revisiting it," he said.

Naidu did not specify what interventions the government was looking at, or what possible tweaks were under consideration.

"West Asia crisis and its burden on industry and ATF prices are important to consider. We are in talks with airlines and oil marketing companies (OMCs) on this. We will see how the talks go," Naidu said on the impact of the West Asia war on the sidelines of an industry programme in Delhi.

Separately, the Federation of Indian Airlines (FIA), representing IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet, has also warned the Centre that airlines could curtail operations and withdraw from unviable routes if rising fuel costs are not addressed, according to a 25 September letter



PTI

reviewed by *Mint*.

The rethink comes as ATF prices for domestic airlines have risen for the third consecutive month. The price in Delhi rose by ₹16 a litre, or 13.22%, to ₹137 a litre in October from ₹121.28 a litre in September, according to Indian Oil Corp. officials. Prices are revised on the first of every month. The October increase is the sharpest in the recent sequence, taking jet-fuel prices about 25% above their July level.

The rise is already feeding into airline pricing. IndiGo, India's largest airline by market share at 65%, has increased fuel surcharges on domestic and international flights, with the steepest increases applying to longer domestic journeys. The airline has now raised fuel charges three times this year, in March, April and October.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

NTPC plans 10 mt coal offtake in second half of FY27

State-run NTPC plans to procure around 10 million tonnes (mt) coal from commercial mines in the second half of financial year 2027 (FY27), said an official on condition of anonymity.

This marks the second year the company will buy from commercial mines, following its procurement of around 11 mt in FY25. For FY27, NTPC projects its total coal requirement at around 300 mt, an 11% increase from FY26. Most of this volume will be supplied through fuel supply agreements with state-run miners, with captive mines contributing the remaining 50 million or so tonnes.

"NTPC plans to source 10-15 mt of coal from commercial miners annually going ahead. This year about 10 mt may come from commercial mines. We have placed orders, delivery will start soon," said the official. NTPC plants are running at a plant load factor 76%, the official added. NTPC also reported about 13% year-on-year growth in power generation to 117.9 billion units.

RITURAJ BARUAH

Manufacturing sentiment improved in Jul-Sep: Ficci

India's manufacturing sentiment improved in the July-September quarter as factories reported higher capacity utilization and higher or same levels of production as compared to the previous quarter, according to the latest edition of the Federation of Indian chambers of commerce and industry (Ficci) manufacturing survey released on Tuesday.

The survey, which covered around 225 firms, assessed the performance and sentiment of manufacturers for nine major sectors, namely automotive and auto components, capital goods, chemicals and allied products, electronics and electricals, glass, machine tools, metal and metal products, textiles, apparels and technical textiles.

According to Ficci, the findings reflect a rebound in the sentiment for production in second quarter of 2026-27 compared to the previous quarter, indicating signs of recovery from the West Asia crisis.

PTI

Auto cos tap green power to cut costs, emissions

FROM PAGE 1

comes as the share of renewable power in companies' electricity consumption reaches an all-time high, with captive projects offering potential power-cost savings of about 10-40%, depending on the state, according to experts.

"Captive solar enables manufacturers to secure a portion of their electricity requirements at a more predictable long-term cost, reduce exposure to grid tariff volatility and lower Scope 2 emissions," said Alekhya Datta, director, electricity and renewables Division, The Energy and Resources Institute (Teri).

"Compared with external renewable procurement through open access, captive generation can provide greater control over the source and cost of electricity, although it may involve higher upfront investment and project-development responsibilities," Datta said.

The push for captive green-power projects also comes as the government nudges manufacturers to increase the use of electricity in the production of parts and vehicles, following disruptions to natural-gas supplies during the West Asia war.

At Mahindra & Mahindra, renewable electricity accounted for 37% of consumption in FY26, up from about 30% in FY25. At Tata Motors' commercial-vehicle business, captive power consumption rose to 51% of its total consumption in FY26, up from 47% in FY25. At Maruti Suzuki, the share rose to 22.8% in FY26 from 21.3% in FY25.

In July, Tata Motors partnered with Welspun Renewable Energy to



Maruti Suzuki commissioned a solar captive plant last year and installed a 1MWh battery energy storage system at its Kharkhoda plant in July this year.

build an 86 MW wind-solar hybrid project that will supply renewable power solely to its manufacturing plants in Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Karnataka.

SJR Kutty, chief sustainability officer at Tata Motors, said that as manufacturing processes become increasingly electrified, the emissions profile of the firm's operations is increasingly influenced by the carbon intensity of the electricity consumed. "Expanding the share of renewable power is therefore fundamental to delivering meaningful emissions reductions across our manufacturing footprint," said Kutty.

"Captive and group captive renewable energy projects typically offer higher savings through regulatory

benefits such as subsidies and waivers. Compared with opex-based renewable power purchase agreements, the additional savings can typically range from approximately ₹1.5 to ₹3 per kWh. Savings are often significantly

higher when compared to green tariff offerings from discoms," said Kutty.

In September, Swaraj Tractors, the tractor arm of Mahindra & Mahindra, commissioned a 42 megawatt-peak (MWp) solar project in Bathinda, Punjab. The project will supply power to Swaraj's operations in Mohali, meeting about half of its electricity requirements.

Maruti Suzuki commissioned a solar captive plant last year and installed a 1 MWh battery energy storage system at its Kharkhoda plant

in Haryana in July this year. The company says the system will store electricity generated from the plant's renewable energy sources and allow the carmaker to use it when required.

"We have aligned our business priorities with the national goal of achieving net-zero. By deploying multiple clean technologies, we aspire to reduce carbon footprint in manufacturing operations from the present 615,000 tonnes per year to 266,000 tonnes per year in FY 2030-31. We have earmarked about ₹1,000 crore towards green energy initiatives by FY31," said Rahul Bharti, senior executive officer of corporate affairs.

Samvardhana Motherhood commissioned a 15 MWp solar project in June in Mahoba, Uttar Pradesh, through its energy arm Motherhood New Energy. The project will supply renewable electricity to multiple Motherhood manufacturing plants in the state and is expected to generate about 23.4 million units of electricity annually.

Mahindra & Mahindra said in its annual report that it had also moved to secure more renewable power for the current financial year.

"For component manufacturers, this is becoming particularly important. Global automotive customers are increasingly looking at the carbon footprint of their supply chains. Demonstrating that products are manufactured using renewable energy will increasingly become important for winning export business, and remaining part of global supply chains," said Vinay Piparsania, founder at Millenstrat Advisory and Research.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)



The 770MW hydroelectric project will strengthen Bhutan's clean energy generation capacity.

AFP

Adani, Druk to set up 770MW project

Adani Power on Tuesday said it has inked a pact with Bhutan's state utility Druk Green Power Corp. Ltd (DGPC) for setting up the 770MW Chamkharchhu-1 Hydroelectric Project in the Kingdom of Bhutan.

Adani Power and DGPC, Bhutan's state-owned generation utility, signed a shareholders agreement. The project marks the second major hydropower collaboration between the two partners, following the 570MW Wangchhu Hydroelectric Project agreement signed in 2025. It is also part of the broader 5,000MW hydropower development memorandum of understanding signed between the Adani Group and DGPC. The project will strengthen Bhutan's clean energy generation capacity and enhance regional energy cooperation. Construction is expected to commence in the first half of 2027.

"Hydropower will play a pivotal role in accelerating South Asia's energy transition, and this project will contribute significantly to enhancing energy security, reducing carbon intensity, and advancing shared sustainability goals," said Anil Sardana, Managing Director, Adani Power Ltd.

PTI

Banks urged to widen digital reach

The Centre is pushing banks to move financial inclusion beyond opening accounts, asking them to expand digital outreach, process loans end-to-end online and widen access to credit for micro-enterprises.

Department of financial services secretary Sanjay Lohiya gave the instructions on Tuesday at a review meeting with the heads of public-sector banks and executive directors of major private-sector banks in New Delhi, according to a finance ministry statement.

The government's financial inclusion push is built around schemes intended to expand access to banking, insurance, pensions and credit. Lohiya also urged banks to participate in the forthcoming financial inclusion saturation campaign, scheduled from 21 October to 31 December, and to give greater attention to marginalized sections and their banking needs.

HARSH KUMAR



South Africa, South Korea, Germany, Hungary and Turkey were also bidders.

BLOOMBERG

India among 7 in 2036 Olympics race

India and Qatar were among seven countries to express interest in hosting the 2036 Summer Olympics, the International Olympic Committee (IOC) said on Tuesday.

India and Qatar have long been seen as favoured candidates in a hosting contest the IOC aims to decide in 2029 by a contested vote of its 100-plus members. The members include Nita Ambani from India's richest family, and the Emir of Qatar, Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani.

South Africa, South Korea, Germany, Hungary and Turkey were also bidders. The IOC added it was talking with the candidates about also possibly hosting in 2040 and 2044.

"But wherever the Games take place, one thing must never change: Athletes have to be at the heart of everything we do," said IOC President Kirsty Coventry, a two-time swimming gold medallist.

AP

SME pharma sees shift from China

Small and mid-size Indian pharmaceutical firms at the CPHI Worldwide 2026 trade exhibition in Milan on Tuesday said they are seeing more orders move from China, particularly for drug intermediates, as Western buyers diversify supply chains, though some cautioned that India still depends on Chinese raw materials and cannot yet match its prices.

CPHI is a major global business-to-business platform for the pharmaceutical industry, bringing together drug manufacturers, application programming interface suppliers, contract development and manufacturing organizations, contract manufacturers, formulation companies and procurement teams. About 40 small and mid-size firms are participating in the Indian government pavilion organized by the Pharmaceuticals Export Promotion Council of India.

PTI

EAM in Ghana to begin 3-nation tour

External affairs minister (EAM) S. Jaishankar arrived in Ghana on Tuesday on the first leg of his three-nation tour to African countries to explore ways to shore up bilateral ties in trade and investment, and infrastructure development.

From Ghana, Jaishankar will travel to Côte d'Ivoire and Ethiopia. His visit is reflective of India's commitment to deepen its partnership with Africa, and will further New Delhi's solidarity with the Global South, the ministry of external affairs said in Delhi while announcing the trip.

During his visit, Jaishankar will hold bilateral talks with his counterparts and meet with the leadership of all three nations to review close bilateral ties of friendship and cooperation. He will also exchange perspectives on regional and global matters of mutual interest. In Addis Ababa, he will chair the Regional Heads of Mission Conference that is expected to be attended by Indian envoys in the region.

PTI



Preparing for Hyrox? Your wallet needs training, too

A three-month preparation cycle in the home city can cost ₹71,000, rising to about ₹1.15 lakh

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MUMBAI

At the Hyrox Mumbai arena inside Nesco's Bombay Exhibition Center on 19 September, the air buzzed with heavy bass, sweat and the whir of weighted sleds. Months of gruelling preparation paid off at the finish line as exhausted but exhilarated athletes were cheered by friends.

Behind the medals and photographs lies a demanding physical—and financial—discipline. The ₹8,500 Hyrox pass is only the start, with specialized training, carbon-plated gear, sports nutrition, travel and recovery adding to costs over the months before the race.

Plated shoes to race simulations
For participants, the race pass is just the beginning of a larger financial commitment. Sai Aravindh, a 25-year-old production supervisor from Coimbatore, spent four months preparing for his first Hyrox in Bengaluru. Besides the registration fee, he spent ₹13,000 on flights, ₹5,000 on local transport and meals, ₹6,000 a month on gym fees and up to ₹5,000 on supplements.

"Switching to Hyrox-specific gym and training saw my training fees more than double month-on-month compared to the usual gym and training," Aravindh said.

To manage the higher costs, he allocated part of his monthly income to fitness spending. "It is definitely a combination of investment and experience. The vibe during Hyrox feels surreal and makes you feel the cost you paid is worth it. It is definitely an investment in your health," he added.

While some athletes opt for specialized centres, others keep gym costs low but face steep equipment and other expenses. Ralph Martin Pinto, 22, former video editor from Mumbai, spent ₹2,000-3,000 a month at a basic gym. But race-appropriate gear quickly raised his costs, including ₹22,000 for Puma Hyrox Deviate shoes.

Partial and full-race simulations cost about ₹1,000 a session, while spectator passes for family added to the bill. His plan to offset some costs through post-race sponsorships fell through after a shin injury before the event, showing how physical setbacks can disrupt financial planning. "Hyrox is indeed an expensive sport. The gyms are very far and super expensive, and to get into a competition, the travel cost to another city and stay, combined with the fees, is too much," Pinto said.

For Dharmil Mehta, 31, a Mumbai-based actuary, preparing independently still involved significant costs. He spent ₹10,000 on registration, ₹15,000 on specialized nutrition such as gels, electrolytes and protein, ₹7,000 on training guidance, ₹25,000 on footwear and equipment and ₹5,000 on massages, viewing the spending as an investment in his health.

Separating essentials from hype
Pooja Rajpal, co-founder of 6262 Fitness and a head judge at major Hyrox events in India, says preparation, rather than registration, is the biggest financial commitment. A basic three-month preparation cycle in home city, including a ₹11,000 entry package, 36 specialized training sessions at ₹900 each, carbon-plated footwear and apparel, costs ₹65,000-71,000, said Rajpal.

Add structured sports-nutrition guidance, monthly physiotherapy and

Hyrox requires physical and financial preparation

From ₹8,500 entry passes to carbon-plated footwear, nutrition and recovery, the associated costs of Hyrox add up. Here's how to prepare.

Participant perspectives

SAI ARAVINDH (25)

Production supervisor, Coimbatore



Switching to Hyrox-specific gym saw my training fees more than double. It's a combination of investment and experience."

RALPH MARTIN PINTO (22)

Former video editor, Mumbai



Hyrox-specialized gyms are expensive. Combined with race fees and gear, the costs can quickly add up."

DHARMIL MEHTA (31)

Qualified actuary, Mumbai



Expenses like specialized gels, shoes, and recovery massages add up. I view the spend as a health investment."

Hyrox spend breakdown in Mumbai

Expense	Item	Estimated cost (in ₹) (for 3 months)
Entry and add-ons	Registration (₹8,000) plus Flex option (₹1,500) plus photos (₹1,500)	11,000
Specialized coaching	Coached sessions (3 months, thrice a week at ₹900-1,800 per session)	32,400-64,800
Footwear and apparel	Carbon-plated shoes (₹20,000) plus workout apparel (₹1,500-8,000)	21,500-28,000
Sports nutrition	Focused nutrition for 3 months (₹6,000-10,000 a month)	18,000-30,000
Recovery	Monthly physio plus contrast therapy (eg. ice bath) for 3 months	12,000-13,500
Outstation travel	Flights, two nights stay, meals, and transit (if applicable)	40,000-50,000
Basic home-city total (Mumbai)	Registration plus 36 basic training sessions plus shoes plus apparel	64,900-71,400
Outstation total	Complete preparation, recovery, outstation travel and stay	1,34,900-1,64,900

Source: Inputs from Pooja Rajpal, Co-founder of 6262 Fitness and Head Judge at Hyrox India events

Financial preparation and discipline

► **Preparation:** Training, footwear and recovery expenses make up most of the budget.

► **Skip:** Branded apparel, gadgets, excessive simulation sessions, and multiple shoes.

► **Hidden costs:** Unexpected expenses like injuries can arise. So, keep a 15-20% buffer.

► **Credit:** Avoid BNPL or overleveraging if possible or repay as soon as possible.

► **Guardrails:** Start budgeting six months in advance, build a medical emergency fund.

► **Post event:** Rebuild used funds, audit spending and clear short-term debts.

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

contrast-recovery sessions, and the cost rises to ₹95,000-₹1.15 lakh. For an outstation event, including flights, accommodation and meals, total spending can reach ₹1.35-1.65 lakh. Athletes should prioritize suitable plated footwear, adequate hydration and timely physiotherapy.

"Participants can avoid buying expensive Hyrox-branded apparel, the multiple pairs of premium shoes, unnecessary supplements, costly gadgets, excessive paid simulations, non-essential recovery sessions and official photographs. Booking travel early can also reduce costs," she added.

Emergency fund

Participating in Hyrox can push lifestyle spending well beyond routine gym fees, straining household budgets. Easy credit and buy-now-pay-later offers can make expensive aspirations seem affordable but risk creating a leveraged lifestyle.

The goal is not to discourage these ambitions, but to prioritize and plan for them, say financial planners. Just as

athletes train physically and mentally, they should prepare financially for the event months in advance.

Preeti Zende, an investment adviser and founder of Apna Dhan Financial Services, says budgeting should begin at least six months before enrolling.

Rather than relying on high-interest credit or dipping into emergency reserves, athletes should build the

required funds systematically. Zende says monthly training costs can exceed ₹10,000, making a 15-20% contingency buffer important for unexpected expenses. "It comes down to picking and setting priorities," said Suresh Sadagopan, founder of Ladder7 Financial Advisories.

"If Hyrox is a priority, spending a lakh or more on specialized gear, training and nutrition is fine provided you have picked your priorities and budgeted for it. Just because it's accessible, everything cannot be a priority."

He also advised against relying on credit, saying athletes should minimize debt and clear short-term borrowings.

Zende also flagged that standard health insurance policies frequently exclude injuries sustained during organized sports or mass-participation events. Competitors should therefore create a dedicated medical contingency fund to cover potential out-of-pocket expenses. Once the event concludes, she said athletes should audit their spending, rebuild depleted funds, clear short-term debts and redirect their monthly training budgets towards long-term goals.

Hyrox offers a unique fitness experience, but its costs require financial guardrails. By distinguishing essential performance tools from avoidable spending, maintaining an emergency fund and funding preparation through disciplined savings, athletes can enjoy the experience without compromising their financial health.



Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

The missing clause that could leave gaps in your estate plan

Rohit Jain & Keshav Singhania

Can a will be legally valid and still be incomplete?

—Name withheld on request

A will may be legally valid and yet fail to dispose of the entire estate. That distinction matters because a valid will is not necessarily a complete will. Specific gifts often receive most of the attention in estate planning: a house to one beneficiary, investments to another, money in a particular account to someone else. But those bequests deal only with the assets expressly covered by them.

Years later, the house may have been sold, bank account closed, and the testator may have acquired new investments, shares or other assets. The will may remain perfectly valid. The difficulty is that those newly acquired assets may not have been specifically dealt with. Unless the will contains an effective residuary provision, part of the estate may remain undisposed of.

The residuary matters

That is precisely the role of the residuary clause. Sections 102 and 103 of the Indian Succession Act, 1925 deal with the residuary legatee.

In essence, they allow a will



ASK MINT ESTATE PLAN

to identify who should receive the residue of the estate and provide that the residuary legatee takes property belonging to the testator at death that has not otherwise been effectively disposed of by the will.

The residue is not confined to assets acquired after the will is executed. It can also absorb property that has not otherwise been effectively disposed of because another testamentary gift fails or lapses. In that sense, the residuary clause is not simply a catch-all for new assets; it is a structural safeguard against gaps in the testamentary scheme. Without one, part of the estate may fall into partial intestacy despite the existence of a valid will.

When gaps emerge

That can have significant consequences. Undisposed assets may become subject to the applicable rules of intestate succession, separate proceedings may become necessary, and the eventual distribution may differ materially from what the testator intended.

That is why the residuary clause should not be treated as boilerplate or an afterthought. The drafting of the residue deserves as much attention as the specific gifts themselves.

It should clearly identify the residuary beneficiary and, where appropriate, provide for substitute beneficiaries so that the residue itself does not fail. The better question is not merely what the will expressly covers, but what happens to everything it does not.

The residuary clause is what helps bridge the gap between a valid will and a complete will.

Rohit Jain is the managing partner and Keshav Singhania is the head of Private Client at Singhania & Co.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare bank FD rates

Bank fixed deposits (FDs) continue to be popular investment products not just among senior citizens, who are looking for guaranteed income, but also among investors who can't stomach risk. But overexposure to FDs is not good, and you need to assess your asset allocation and goals to decide how much money you should park in them. For instance, saving for your child's higher education that's 15 years away through FDs may not be effective as the post-tax interest rate of an FD may not give you a real return (return that's above the rate of inflation). But if you plan to take a holiday in two years, an FD can help. Before choosing an FD, you should compare the interest rates on offer. Here is a list of banks that offer the highest FD rates for deposits up to ₹1 crore over various tenures.



Interest rates (%) for fixed deposits up to ₹1 crore					
	6 months to < 1 year	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.00-6.50	6.90-7.10	6.90-7.50	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	5.50-6.00	6.55-6.60	6.75-7.05	6.80	6.85
YES Bank	4.75-6.50	6.65-7.25	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	4.75-6.05	6.90-7.00	7.00	7.00	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.30-6.50	6.60-7.25	7.00	6.70	6.70
IndusInd Bank	5.75-6.25	6.75-6.90	7.00	6.65-7.00	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	5.50-7.00	6.25-7.10	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.25	6.50-6.60
Axis Bank	5.50-5.75	6.25-6.50	6.50	6.50	6.50
ICICI Bank	4.50-5.50	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Federal Bank	4.50-6.00	6.25-6.65	6.50-6.55	6.40-6.70	6.40
Karur Vysya Bank	6.00-7.00	6.55-7.20	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	5.00-6.00	6.35-6.55	6.65	6.40	6.25
Canara Bank	5.25-5.50	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
City Union Bank	5.75-6.25	6.65-7.25	6.50	6.25-6.50	6.25
HDFC Bank	4.25-5.75	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	4.50-5.50	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 5 October 2026. Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

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Source: www.BankBazaar.com

GROUP HEALTH INSURANCE NEEDS BETTER UNDERWRITING, NOT LOWER COMMISSION



POWER POINT
KAPIL MEHTA

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

In recent weeks, there has been considerable discussion around the Irdai consultation paper on distribution reforms. A central premise is that insurance commissions are too high and contribute to difficulties policyholders face.

Insurance is diverse, and challenges vary across segments. Retail health, motor and credit life insurance each merit their own analysis. I write about group health insurance for company employees, a segment I know well. It is a large, growing market where intermediaries play a significant role. But here, commission is not the central issue.

Before 2017, the commission allowed for brokers was 17.5% of premium. Until 2023, the commission limit in employer-employee group health was reduced to 7.5%, with an additional reward. In 2023, product-level limits were done away with. Since then, commission has remained mostly unchanged, well under 7.5% for large companies and 7.5%-10% for smaller businesses.

The only change was that commission and reward were merged.

Thin economics

Consider the economics of distributing group health insurance. For a company with 100 lives, the typical annual premium is about ₹6 lakh. Intermediaries will generally earn ₹45,000 as commission and incur costs of about ₹40,000, leaving a profit of ₹5,000, or about a 10% margin.

What are these costs? A salesperson would engage with 10 potential clients to close one. In each engagement, the salesperson suggests coverages, evaluates benefits, benchmarks quotes from five insurers and negotiates for the best terms. Clients, even small ones, work with multiple intermediaries to drive prices down. There is an effective price-lowering auction operating.

After placement, a policy moves to servicing. Each year, there will be five to 10 engagement meetings with HR and employees explaining benefits. With 100 lives, there will be six to 10 claims managed by the claims team, who help at hospital discharge for cashless claims and with reimbursement claims. Costs increase when insurers ask for original bills. Each time an employee joins or leaves, the intermediary must update the employee list, recalculate premiums and deliver health cards. Such endorsements happen 12 to 15 times a year. Some insurers require a person to physically visit their office for endorsement.

Technology adds costs through employee surveys, portals and apps. Clients also expect value-added services such as webinars, onsite activities, Zumba and health checkups. If commission is capped at 2.5%, revenue will fall to ₹15,000, leading to ₹25,000



loss. This is unsustainable, and tech or cost-cutting cannot bridge the gap. All these activities are necessary for effective delivery, and removing an intermediary does not eliminate the tasks.

An outlier

The consultation paper reports that the maximum commission on group health insurance was 93% of premium. This is an outlier. Why did the insurer pay so much? No one can force them. Why did the client agree? Was it an affinity group where members bore the cost? This should be considered a market conduct

issue rather than symptomatic of the industry. In employer-employee group insurance, I have consistently found insurers stingy, unwilling to part with a single extra rupee of commission.

Intermediaries have limited room to negotiate. Virtually every group health client works with multiple intermediaries to discover price floors. If one intermediary priced insurance high for more commission, another would win the account with better terms. This keeps the system fair.

Look at underwriting

Insurers do lose money on group health but due to underwriting practices rather than commissions. Public sector insurers, with the lowest commissions, have the highest claim ratio in group health, at 104% in FY25, as per Irdai report. Insurers must strengthen underwriting discipline. They should walk away from competitive situations

that require them to quote low or pay excess commission. When final regulations are notified, the regulator could factor in the cost of providing service. It should consider significantly higher rates for smaller companies and MSMEs. Improving policyholder outcomes is essential. This matters for intermediaries too if we are to retain clients and scale up. The solutions require a segment-wise assessment and careful consideration of unintended consequences, rather than a broad-brush approach.

Kapil Mehta, co-founder, SecureNow Insurance Broker.



OUR VIEW



We must make the most of India's genetic wealth

A Nobel prize for optogenetics draws a major biotech opportunity into the spotlight. Genetic data offers a hotbed for medical innovation if regulation gets its speed-safety balance right

The 2026 Nobel Prize in Medicine was awarded to three pioneers of optogenetics, the science of controlling body cells with light. By granting researchers control of biological processes with extraordinary precision, their work marked a profound shift in therapeutic exploration. Such advances are of special value to India, which has been laying its own foundation for precision therapy through the Genome India Project and has so far sequenced more than 10,000 genomes that represent 83 diverse populations. While gene studies can identify a genetic defect, the field of optogenetics uses light to control how specific cells behave. As a biological tool, it can map and modulate cells that rely on electrical signals or ion flows. Yet, broad genome mapping is only a starting point. Precise genes and pathways need to be identified. Labs at the National Centre for Biological Sciences and Centre for Neuroscience at the Indian Institute of Science are deploying optogenetics to map circuits that govern pain, itches and other ailments. This emerging field holds immense clinical promise for restoring vision among sufferers of retinal diseases such as retinitis pigmentosa.

Funding is becoming less of a hurdle. India's budget for 2026-27 includes a ₹10,000 crore Biopharma Shakti scheme, even as the biotech part of the Centre's Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) fund signals a policy push. Startups such as ImmunoAct have commercialized indigenous low-cost Car-T cell therapy, while firms such as MedGenome have attracted venture capital from abroad for large-scale gene sequencing. The bottleneck has been India's complex and risk-averse bureaucracy, whose demands of compliance are observed to slow

ventures down in what's clearly a global race. The US has an edge in its industry-academia links; China has sought to accelerate therapies from labs to clinical use. Indian developers still face significant friction. The RDI fund under the Anusandhan mission aims to catalyse deep-tech, but India still lacks a dedicated neurotech mission capable of bringing together physics, engineering and genetics. Till recently, it was hard to import specialized viral vectors and get approvals for gene-editing clinical trials from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation, with timeline uncertainty proving costly for deep-tech startups.

Safety versus speed is a global dilemma. However, even the cautious EU is giving its rules some flexibility for faster progress. Biotech reforms are expected to reset that balance in the US, which had been watching China ease its regulations. To be sure, India has also charted a similar course, with its regulatory apparatus adopting the role of an active enabler. Recent tweaks of clinical-trial rules have streamlined licensing and helped shorten the drug-development cycle. The new Biological Research Regulatory Approval Portal offers single-window clearances. To sustain this momentum, though, India needs to further ease clinical testing, upgrade its system of patent approval and give pharma players a stronger nudge to create high-value intellectual property. Endowed with vast gene pools, the country is wealthy in terms of genetic data. As advances in the science of it—such as optogenetics—get domestic labs whirring to develop clinical applications, we must find safe ways to keep pace with the wider world of biotech without letting regulation stifle innovation. New paths to better health await being lit up. And we have what it takes.

Public debt comes at a price and somebody must pick up the tab

Excessive state borrowing drives up inflation if the central bank can't let a government go insolvent



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In September 1992, Scott Bessent worked for George Soros on the famous trade that broke the pound. The Quantum Fund built a position against the sterling that the Bank of England could not defend, and the bet made a billion dollars for the traders.

Bessent now runs the US Treasury, and thus finds himself on the other side of the battle. He told yen traders in September: "I am the house now." Bond investors heard it too. They have relentlessly pushed up yields on US government debt that is due in 10 years. London taught Bessent that a government holds a price only as long as the market allows it to.

Public debt levels have climbed across the world over the past two decades, especially in developed economies. Much of the reaction to this till now was based on one truth and one misunderstanding. The truth is that a sovereign country issuing debt in its own currency cannot be forced into default since it can always print money to pay back investors. However, it led to the misunderstanding that governments can borrow without facing any major consequences. A government may have control over the quantity of debt it issues, but not over the price at which the market is ready to absorb the extra borrowing.

The International Monetary Fund

has also warned that investor patience is running thin. In the April 2026 edition of its *Fiscal Monitor*, the multilateral lender said: "Policymakers should realise that the markets are becoming less forgiving. Over the past year, investors have increasingly questioned assumptions of unlimited sovereign borrowing capacity—even for large advanced economies." The weight of public debt as a percentage of gross domestic product (GDP) is expected to keep rising over the next few years.

What is the way out? The mathematics of public debt dynamics tells us a simple story. Three things mainly matter—the rate of an economy's nominal GDP growth, the average interest rate at which its government borrows, and the primary balance in the government budget. Public debt is more sustainable when the underlying economy grows much faster than the cost of borrowing. If that is not so, then the government budget has to tighten through either tax increases or spending cuts.

There are two ways to understand these dynamics. The first comes from a paper written by Neil Wallace and Thomas Sargent in 1981. They show that if the interest rate exceeds the growth rate ($r > g$) and primary deficits persist, debt compounds faster than the economy. When the central bank refuses to monetize it, the government's solvency depends on future surpluses. When the central bank gives in, the bill arrives as inflation. Either way, someone pays.

The other way is what is called the fiscal theory of the price level. The real value of outstanding debt must equal the present value of expected primary surpluses. If markets doubt those surpluses will materialize, the adjustment comes through the price level or through higher required yields. Solvency is not the question. The question is who bears the loss, and when.

Wallace and Sargent build their analysis on the standard monetarist view that higher money supply drives the price level. The central bank prints

money to avoid default, expanding money supply over time. The fiscal theory of the price level expects all government liabilities—money supply as well as bonds—to drive the price level. Investors realize future taxes won't cover the debt. They dump government debt or the currency, driving up prices immediately rather than waiting for money-printing by the central bank.

US President Donald Trump added a further dose of confusion when he said a few weeks ago that the US military would be "the ultimate intervention" in the bond market. Nobody can say for sure what he meant by this typically whimsical statement, but one possibility is that he was alluding to the use of state power to bring the bond market to heel. Financial repression, in other words.

Financial repression essentially means that a government uses regulations to keep the cost of borrowing lower than what a free market would have, thus letting inflation and low nominal yields gradually erode public debt over time. This tool was used in the aftermath of World War II, when countries came out of the conflagration with immense debt burdens as a result of the heavy borrowing needed to fund their war efforts.

The old global trade order based on the free flow of goods across national boundaries has already been shaken by growing protectionism. In a column in *Business Standard*, T.N. Ninan asked a provocative question: Will heightened competition for financial resources due to the borrowing binge of governments lead to not just higher inflation but also "restrictions on cross-country capital flows?"

Financial repression has never been successfully tried in an economy open to inflows as well as outflows of capital. The reason is simple. Suppressing the interest rate on government bonds will lead to a flight of capital, which means that trying to manage a debt crisis through financial repression could push many of the major economies in the world towards capital controls.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

We need 10,000 genomes, not 100, to start to understand the link between genetics, disease and wellness.

CRAIG VENTER

GUEST VIEW

Why India requires a fresh wave of economic reforms

RAJIV MEMANI



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Amid geopolitical uncertainties, rising energy prices and inflationary pressures, global economic growth is expected to slow down. Against this backdrop, India has demonstrated remarkable resilience, recording 7.8% growth in the first quarter of 2026-27. The government's deft handling of the West Asia crisis, coupled with robust consumption, growing capital expenditure and economic reforms, has helped India maintain a strong momentum.

Goods and services tax (GST) reforms: GST rate rationalization and procedural simplification in September 2025 represent a major reform, in addition to others that have strengthened demand. Sales of listed fast-moving consumer goods companies grew 10.2% between October 2025 and June 2026, against just 1.9% a year earlier; consumer durables grew 31.2% against 16.1%.

Simultaneously, private investment is gathering pace across renewable energy, steel, cement, chemicals and data centres. Gross fixed capital formation grew 11.9% in

April-June, while bank credit to industry is growing at its fastest pace in over a decade.

Tax revenues have held up too. Higher transaction volumes have more than made up for lower GST rates. GST collections, excluding compensation cess, rose 14.7% in September and are up 11.6% year-on-year during the April-September period. Base income tax collections for April-August are also up 14-15%, lifting the Centre's gross tax revenues by 6.2% despite lower excise duties and the end of the compensation cess. With the base effect of that cess wearing off from October, overall tax revenue growth is expected to rise.

This reinforces the case for more GST reforms. Section 17(5) of the Central GST Act blocks input tax credit on a wide range of goods and services. The government should progressively narrow this list, allowing credit on all business inputs covering both goods and services, except in cases of personal consumption or where there's a risk of revenue leakage. Input credits on capital spending may be allowed to be utilized over a longer time frame to support capital investments. The 'one taxpayer, one audit' principle, under which a taxpayer is audited by only one government for a given period, would ease compliance—at a minimum, this could be implemented at the Central level.

Plugging supply-chain gaps: Pragmatic initiatives such as for coal gasification, nuclear power, the urea policy, Samudra Manthan and the expansion of renewable energy supply chains are designed to address India's high oil import bill. However, the non-oil trade deficit is widening too. Steps like the

expansion of the Electronics Components Manufacturing Scheme, Mobile Manufacturing production-linked incentives 2.0 and Semicon 2.0 will help tackle the issue. But managing it in a dynamic geopolitical environment also needs real-time, product-level data on imports and domestic production to identify vulnerabilities.

To solve this, eight-digit HSN codes should be made mandatory in all GST filings, in line with customs filings. GST returns today can use four-, six- or eight-digit codes. Smaller businesses could be exempted to curtail compliance complexity.

Once high-dependence products are identified, constraints such as inadequate scale, limited technology access, supply-chain bot-

tlenecks and global overcapacity could be addressed through an inter-ministerial task force, which could develop a roadmap and start local production.

Attracting foreign direct investment (FDI): The flurry of free trade agreements signed provide an opportunity to boost FDI, since

trade and investments go hand-in-hand. As countries seek to strategically diversify and reduce dependence on any single region, India, with its expanding economy, could gain. A high-level committee can be set up as the single decision-making authority with powers to approve and expedite investments. It could facilitate land, infrastructure, environmental clearances and coordination with states.

Investors also seek legal and tax certainty. Over ₹16 trillion of direct tax disputes stuck at the commissioner of income tax (appeals) level must be resolved quickly. To prevent a fresh backlog, the government should strengthen alternative dispute resolution mechanisms such as mediation and consider

checks and balances before issuance of new notices. A clear stand is needed against retrospective implementation of tax laws.

Enhance the ease of doing business: While the Government's high-powered committees have made significant progress on this front, there is scope for further simplification. Various industry clusters have cited slow land allotment, delays in building-plan approvals and a shortage of large contiguous parcels. Some pharmaceutical and biotechnology companies report that greenfield projects take 36-48 months to begin commercial production, even though facilities can be built within 24 months.

Industries have highlighted the prevalence of overlapping jurisdictions, compliance requirements and audits. For example, in the petroleum sector, the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organization, Oil Industry Safety Directorate and the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board oversee aspects of petroleum infrastructure.

Time-bound approvals, single-window clearances and clearly demarcated regulatory roles would lower compliance costs and support capital expenditure. Amid geopolitical uncertainty, sustained reforms are key to increase competitiveness, economic growth, resilience and job creation.

Sustained reforms will help enhance competitiveness and accelerate growth as well as job creation



THEIR VIEW

Four big reasons why the global economy has proven so resilient

The most important of these is a positive supply shock in the shape of AI investment. We may face trouble if this goes wrong



NOURIEL ROUBINI

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Despite the rising risks, uncertainties and large negative supply shocks of the last two years, stock markets and the overall global economy have held up quite well. Following the shock of US President Donald

Trump's 'Liberation Day' (2 April) tariffs in 2025 came this year's Iran War, which caused the largest energy shock since the oil crises of the 1970s.

Yet, according to International Monetary Fund data, global growth was as high in 2025 as it was in 2024 (3.5%), and global inflation was lower in 2025 than in 2024. And while global growth is expected to slow to 3% this year, it is projected to recover (to 3.4%) in 2027, with inflation returning towards its 2025 level in 2027 after rising in 2026.

What explains the global economy's apparent resilience and what are the biggest downside risks to the relatively benign outlook for 2027?

Four major factors have prevented a downturn. *First*, market discipline forced the Trump administration to shelve its most stagflationary policies. Average US tariff rates spiked from 2.1% in January 2025 to 21.5% on 2 April 2025, but that triggered a market reaction that forced Trump to blink and negotiate tariff reductions. The average tariff rate is now 9.6%. Likewise, Trump's decision to go to war against Iran caused an oil-price shock, rising bond yields and a stock-market correction, leading him to negotiate a fragile ceasefire that partly reversed some of the damage.

Second, the tariff and oil shocks were mitigated by adjustments in trade patterns, global supply chains and other production factors. With many new producers and sources of energy, the world today depends less on oil than in the past. A draw-down in strategic oil reserves (especially in China) and some demand destruction dampened the impact of the shock substantially.

Third, policy responses helped absorb some of the impact. There was fiscal and monetary easing in many advanced economies in 2025, when growth seemed to be at risk, followed by monetary tightening this year to keep inflation expectations anchored.

Fourth, and most importantly, the world is in the middle of a massive positive long-term aggregate supply shock, owing to the AI investment boom. The US and China are the clear leaders, but many other countries in Asia and Europe are also benefiting from this capital-expenditure cycle, which increasingly includes higher defence spending.

Still, there are tail risks to consider. For starters, geopolitical tensions are high, shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remains constrained and uncertain, and recent Houthi attacks on shipping chokepoints and a Saudi pipeline may further restrict oil and gas supplies. Oil prices have already spiked above \$100 per barrel again, and the longer



that energy prices remain elevated, the greater the stagflationary pressure.

Moreover, the recent extension of the Sino-American truce may not last if China—with its *de facto* allies, Russia, Iran and North Korea—feels emboldened by US geo-strategic missteps. Tensions over Taiwan could rise after the island's elections in 2028 and the Russia-Ukraine conflict is expanding to a wider theatre with Ukraine striking deep inside Russia and Russia pursuing hybrid warfare against Europe. Given Ukraine's targeting of Russian energy facilities, a failure to secure a ceasefire will put additional upward pressure on hydrocarbon prices.

Meanwhile, liberal democracies are showing signs of political dysfunction; upcoming elections in the US, France, Germany, Italy and Spain could lead to more populist economic policies that would damage growth and introduce greater fiscal risks. Indeed, large fiscal deficits and high debt-to-GDP ratios in many advanced economies and some emerging markets are driving up sovereign bond yields, threatening to crowd out private-sector production, capex and consumption, and raising the risk of credit crises.

The AI boom is another source of risk—and is showing signs of frothiness. If it proves to be a bubble that must eventually pop or deflate, the result could be negative wealth effects (lower consumption), credit problems and a loss of animal spirits among investors and households.

On the policy front, stagflationary shocks that reduce growth and increase inflation tend to create a dilemma for central banks with a dual mandate to

maintain both price stability and full employment. If they conclude that additional rate hikes are warranted to fight inflation, that may weaken growth and raise financial-stability concerns, given high levels of private and public debt and the risk of debt monetization ('printing money').

In the baseline scenario, these negative risks remain contained, global economic growth improves in 2027 and inflation falls as productivity-enhancing tech innovations provide a strong tailwind for the global economy. In this case, high bond yields will be driven more by the AI boom than by concerns about inflation or fiscal deficits and debt. Moreover, an easing of geopolitical tensions is certainly possible and would reduce energy prices, creating the conditions for the positive—even double-digit—equity returns of recent years to continue.

But if the big risks do materialize, energy and commodity prices may remain high or rise further, and trade and supply chains could be more severely disrupted. That would significantly raise the risk of a serious market correction, with both higher bond yields and lower equity prices.

The more positive scenario is still the more likely one. Tech tailwinds remain strong, market discipline will still contain the worst policies and the US and China both seem committed to de-escalating their rivalry. Given the scope of potential risks, one must hope that the current resilience will continue. Much will depend on political leaders avoiding extremes and not derailing one of the most important technological innovations in human history.

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MINT CURATOR

The internet isn't ready for the new kids on the block: agents

AI bots trained just to achieve goals could potentially wreak havoc



PARMY OLSON

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Guardrails may not suffice to keep personal AI agents ethical.

BLOOMBERG

Earlier this year an Australian tech worker asked his OpenClaw artificial intelligence (AI) agent whether it could get him higher up on the waiting list for a popular gym class. It did exactly what he wanted, but with an unexpected twist: It found a flaw in the system and cancelled the booking of another person on the list.

AI's next big magic trick is to start doing things for users across the web, with new tools like Muse from Meta and Dots from OpenAI working 24x7 to find online bargains, book restaurant tables or check emails. What's troubling is how these increasingly capable and arguably useful tools are trained to find creative ways to meet their goals, which could lead to unintended consequences when unleashed on an internet full of poorly secured websites.

The Australian tech worker's AI agent had found a loophole and exploited it without being told to. So what happens when millions of other people's agents start competing for the cheapest flights or the best movie seats? In the best-case scenario, we will see a smooth and well-functioning network of bots that play by the rules to get the best outcomes for their humans. In the worst: a cyber security nightmare.

The web simply might not be ready. Security firm DataDome says 65% of the more than 20,000 websites it tested had systems for detecting or blocking AI agents, and that bot activity hitting login pages rose more than eightfold in the first half of 2026.

In some ways it is hard to imagine these new AI agents causing widespread trouble. They look too cute for a start. Muse has a cartoonish design reminiscent of a Labubu doll, while the vividly covered blobs that represent dots could be characters in a children's TV show—perhaps part of an effort to ease general mistrust of Meta and OpenAI.

They work well too. *Bloomberg's* Dave Lee called Muse "the most impressive product Meta has released in years." He said his agent, which he had christened Harold, had organized his calendar and scoured Facebook Marketplace for good deals.

Both Meta and OpenAI say they have strong guardrails in place to make sure their agents behave themselves. Muse is kept within an isolated virtual machine—essentially a private computer in Meta's cloud—while a separate security system controls every request it makes on the internet, handling payments and making sure a human is consulted before any major task like buying something or sending a message. Dots is monitored in a similar way.

But even these safeguards don't fix an underlying problem baked into today's

Generative AI models through training: a tendency to look for shortcuts, a phenomenon researchers call reward-hacking. This is also why chatbots are prone to flattery. The UK's AI Security Institute noticed a rise in this kind of cheating behaviour in coding agents and chatbots late last year.

An inclination to please is what drove OpenAI's agents to hack HuggingFace a few months ago. OpenAI agents also improperly meddled with the websites of dozens of other organizations this year, including the US Securities and Exchange Commission and Australia's government-run healthcare scheme. Meta says one of its AI models too hacked another company of its own accord.

These cases happened while the models were being trained or tested, with safeguards deliberately lowered. But the bots' actions still surprised their developers and researchers have noticed that even when they make their tests harder to game, agents keep trying to cheat.

There are signs that AI products will also hunt for loopholes in the wild, particularly in coding. In one instance, a software developer told his AI agent to clear out temporary files from a computer folder without using the 'delete' command. The agent then hid that instruction inside a testing tool and slipped past the filter to clear the files using the command it was told not to.

Now multiply that type of behaviour by million of agents as consumers explore using AI to optimize their lives and work. When Meta boss Mark Zuckerberg launched Muse last month, he said consumers deserved to have access to their own "personal superintelligence" and that the new agents would "make you money."

Some aren't doing that very well. When a consumer tech reviewer in Toronto named Matt J. Robb tried using Muse to sell a keyboard on Facebook Marketplace last month, the agent angered the buyer by saying Robb was at home to carry out the transaction, which wasn't true. The agent had also made a low-ball offer. On top of the risk of cheating, agents can also just make mistakes, and it will likely be end users who pay the price. Robb was left with a negative rating from his angry buyer.

However cuddly these new agents look, the systems behind them are trained to tick a box one way or another. They might do a little too well.

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MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

India's data centre policy must address local concerns

RAHUL MATTHAN



is a partner at Trilegal and the author of 'The Third Way: India's Revolutionary Approach to Data Governance'. His X handle is @matthan.

This July, several hundred residents of Thane formed a human chain outside a 53-acre plot in Balkum that had been earmarked for a hyperscale data centre. They were agitating against the noise and heat it would generate, and the water it would consume in a city that is already struggling to supply its residents. This, as far as I can tell, was the first time Indians have taken to the streets against a data centre. It will not be the last.

The arguments they were making are not new. Claims that each question we put to ChatGPT consumes half a litre of water and uses 10 times the electricity of a Google search have been around since 2023. But the soundness of these allegations have been questioned. The figures, it is said, come from outdated publications that misrepresent current facts. In August last year, Google stated that a median text prompt to Gemini consumes 0.24 watt-hours of electricity and 0.26 millilitres (about five drops) of water. If this is correct, then each prompt costs

roughly what a Google search does—far less than what is alleged. But Google's figure is a median for text and conveniently ignores the fact that reasoning models consume a hundred times and video generators about 4,000 times that figure for a 5-second clip.

What is much harder to defend is the noise pollution caused by the incessant whine of fans that are needed to keep servers cool. Because of its steady, low frequency, it carries in a way that noise pollution caused by traffic does not. That said, a well-built data centre can keep the sound to between 45 and 65 decibels at its fence, which is quieter than a highway.

The other concerns are also less alarming than they appear to be at first glance. Data centres used about 1.5% of the world's electricity in 2024 and produced 0.5% of its emissions from fuel combustion. This is about a fifth of the energy we consume for air-conditioning and the International Energy Agency expects them to account for less than a tenth of additional demand projected till 2030. The Council on Energy, Environment and Water puts Indian data centres at two or three hundredths of a per cent of our water demand.

None of this is to suggest that protestors in Thane are wrong to worry. The environ-

mental cost of AI should not be calculated on a per-prompt basis, but must instead be evaluated in terms of where each data centre is built, what powers it, and who it is going to affect because they live next door to it. In Ireland, since hyperscalers were allowed to cluster around Dublin, 23% of its electricity now goes to data centres.

Two-thirds of the data centres built in the US since 2022 sit in places already short of water. By that reckoning, India is also building them in exactly the wrong places. Google's \$15 billion AI hub in Visakhapatnam is coming up in a district with the lowest groundwater in Andhra Pradesh, while Mumbai, which accounts for over half of our installed data centre capacity, had to ration water this summer.

The draft National Data Centre Policy that India's ministry of electronics and information technology (IT) circulated last year ties its incentives to power-usage effectiveness (the ratio of the electricity a facility draws to what its servers actually use). However, it

does not appear to have addressed issues about water, siting or noise. Since the cheapest route to power-usage effectiveness is evaporative cooling, we may find ourselves trading electricity efficiency for chronic water shortages.

Last year, I argued in this column that we should run the same playbook that built our IT industry to succeed at AI. But that is only half of what we need to do. The other half has to do with addressing the concerns of Balkum's residents.

What needs to be done is not difficult. Wherever measures like this have been demanded, they have eventually been taken. When a Uruguayan court forced Google to disclose that its Canelones data cen-

tre would draw 7.6 million litres of drinking water a day, the public reaction was enough to get the company to redesign it to run on air-cooled chillers. Microsoft's Hyderabad data centre runs a closed loop that consumes almost no water for cooling. In Chandler, Arizona, the noise produced by a data centre

can never exceed the ambient level of the baseline recorded prior to construction. Karnataka's new policy requires data centres to report their water use every year, and Maharashtra has commissioned standards for siting, water and noise.

Our national policy must address these concerns head on. Every data centre should be obliged to report both its water-usage and power-usage effectiveness. Every new site should pass a test that weighs the water stress of the basin it draws from and the homes that depend on the same water. The noise it emits while operating at peak load should never exceed the baseline measured before construction. None of this will slow the industry down. These are all measures that have been adopted elsewhere and the technology exists to make it feasible.

Stories about the amount of water AI consumes will outlive our attempts to correct the narrative—because the myth is far more vivid than reality. But all that residents of Balkum really want is the assurance that the facility that's being built would not impose an impossible burden on those who have to live with it. These are concerns that our data centre policy can easily address, and since we have not yet finalized it, it is not too late to include them.

Worries over noise plus their use of water and electricity need not get in the way of their proliferation

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Season 3

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Capital for the Next Leap



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